



School Counseling Handbook

Comprehensive School Counseling Program Manual

JUNE 2026

Saint Louis Public Schools School Counseling Handbook

Comprehensive School Counseling Program Manual

Our City. Our Schools. Our Future.

A district handbook aligned to the Missouri Comprehensive School Counseling Program.

This handbook describes the district program foundation, delivery components, school-level implementation, counselor roles, program management expectations, evaluation practices, and operating procedures for a comprehensive school counseling program.

The manual is written for counselors and school leaders who need a practical reference for planning, delivering, documenting, and improving school counseling services across elementary, middle, and high school settings.

Saint Louis Public Schools (SLPS)
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Purpose and Use

This handbook establishes a common operating framework for the Saint Louis Public Schools comprehensive school counseling program. It aligns district practice to the Missouri Comprehensive School Counseling Program while preserving local expectations for planning, service delivery, documentation, and program improvement.

The handbook is written for school counselors, principals, district leaders, Human Resources, and partners who support school counseling implementation. The text is intended to function as an operating manual: it explains the program model, describes expectations, and gives schools a common structure for planning and improvement.

Where district procedure controls an activity, the handbook directs staff to current SLPS procedure rather than restating legal or HR language that may change independently of this manual.

Program Overview

This handbook follows the district comprehensive school counseling manual structure and applies that structure throughout the document. The section sequence is used as the organizing format for the manual rather than as a separate reference table.

Section I: Introduction

- Brief description of the district's comprehensive school counseling program.
- Acknowledgements and district leadership support for the program.
- Purpose, beliefs, vision, mission, assurances, and local rationale.

Section II: Content Areas and MLSs

- Academic development, career development, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development.
- Missouri Learning Standards alignment.
- Grade-level student outcomes and planning priorities.

Section III: Structural Foundation

- Mission and vision.
- School counseling program facilities.
- Advisory council.
- Staffing patterns and program resources.

Section IV: Program Components

- School counseling curriculum: overview and delivery.



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- Individual student planning: overview and delivery, including ICAP.
- Individual Planning with SchoolLinks.
- Responsive services: individual counseling, small-group counseling, crisis counseling, consultation, and referral process.
- Social Services with CareSolace.
- Scheduling with Focus Student Information System.
- System support, program management, evaluation, professional development, collaboration, community outreach, and program advocacy.
- Suggested distributions of school counselor time.

Section V: Job Descriptions

- School counselor responsibilities for elementary, middle, and high school.
- Director, coordinator, registrar, and clerical support responsibilities where applicable.

Section VII: Ethical Standards

- Relevant professional association standards and ethical practice expectations.
- Local procedures that protect ethical, legal, and consistent student support.

Section VIII: School Board Policy

- Board policies and district procedures that govern the comprehensive school counseling program.
- Transition, implementation, evaluation, enhancement, and manual maintenance expectations.



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SECTION I

Introduction

Purpose, acknowledgements, beliefs, mission, assurances, and district rationale.

Purpose of the Handbook

This handbook establishes the district framework for school counseling services in Saint Louis Public Schools. It is intended to help schools provide a consistent, comprehensive program while allowing building-level adaptation to student needs.

The handbook should be used as a working guide for annual planning, role clarity, service delivery, program evaluation, and communication with stakeholders. It does not replace current district policy or negotiated agreements.

The SLPS school counseling program is built around student development, equitable service, collaboration, and current Missouri CSCP expectations for program management.

Beliefs

The SLPS school counseling program rests on the belief that every student has a right to meaningful access to a school counselor and to a planned program of academic, career, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development.

Counselors are part of the school community team. Their work depends on collaboration with administrators, teachers, families, support staff, health professionals, and community partners.

Effective implementation requires supportive leadership, appropriate physical space, reasonable staffing, protected time, useful data, and clear role expectations. These conditions allow counselors to deliver services rather than simply react to crises or perform unrelated administrative tasks.

The program should be continuously refined through student need data, stakeholder feedback, counselor reflection, and annual results review.

Vision

SLPS students will graduate with the academic preparation, career awareness, self-knowledge, relationship skills, and postsecondary plan needed to pursue meaningful futures.

The vision is not limited to high school completion. It begins in elementary school with foundational learning habits and self-awareness, continues in middle school through transition and exploration, and becomes concrete in high school through graduation planning and postsecondary transition.



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Mission

The mission of the SLPS school counseling program is to support the academic, career, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development of all students through a comprehensive, data-informed program.

The program is delivered through school counseling curriculum, individual student planning, responsive services, and system support. Counselors provide direct services to students and indirect services on behalf of students through consultation, collaboration, referral, and program leadership.

Program Assurances

A comprehensive program requires district and school support. Schools should provide time for planning and implementation, receive periodic program reports, act on decisions needed for program development, communicate counseling services to the school community, and provide resources needed to sustain the program.

Students should have access to counselors, and counselors should have access to students. The program should provide equitable service regardless of student background, identity, disability, academic record, or family circumstance.

District leadership is responsible for maintaining formal commitments related to policy, staffing, and budget authority.

Program Adoption and Implementation

Program adoption is the process of translating a district model into visible practice in each school. It begins with leadership support, a common structure, identified student competencies, and clear priorities drawn from student need and program evidence.

Each school should define its local program structure, identify priority student outcomes by grade band, compare current counselor time with the desired program balance, and identify the resources needed for implementation.

Implementation should produce a written annual plan, a master calendar, advisory council agenda, needs-assessment summary, use-of-time review, and annual results report. These artifacts make the program visible and allow the district to improve it over time.

District Counseling Goals and Needs Assessment Priorities

District counseling goals should be set through student need data, program planning surveys, district priorities, and annual program review. Four district priorities should remain central to school counseling planning.



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Students should apply the skills needed for educational achievement; understand themselves as individuals and as members of diverse local and global communities; participate in positive, safe, and respectful learning environments; and prepare for college, career, military, apprenticeship, employment, or other postsecondary pathways that fit their goals.

Needs assessment should include students, families, teachers, counselors, principals, and other relevant staff. Results should identify the district and school priorities that shape curriculum, planning, responsive services, professional learning, and annual program goals.

The annual needs-assessment summary should name the highest priority student competencies, the student groups or grade bands most affected, the planned response, and the evidence that will be reviewed after implementation.

Student Competency Outcomes

The comprehensive school counseling program helps students develop the knowledge, skills, and habits needed for school success, healthy relationships, and postsecondary readiness.

Across grade levels, students should build self-understanding, motivation to achieve, decision-making and problem-solving skills, interpersonal effectiveness, communication skills, cross-cultural effectiveness, responsible behavior, and personal safety skills.

These competencies should be taught and reinforced through the three current Missouri content areas: academic development, career development, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development.

Rationale

Students must be viewed as whole persons. Academic performance, attendance, behavior, mental health, family conditions, transition needs, and future planning are connected. A comprehensive school counseling program gives schools a structure for responding to those connections intentionally.

The Missouri CSCP framework emphasizes that school counseling is a program, not simply a position. This distinction matters for SLPS because consistent program delivery cannot depend solely on individual counselor habits or building-by-building custom.

A district handbook gives counselors and principals a common language for planning services, clarifying duties, and evaluating whether the counseling program is reaching students.



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SECTION II

Content Areas and Missouri Learning Standards

Current Missouri content areas, standards alignment, and local adaptation.

Framework Overview

The Missouri Comprehensive School Counseling Program is organized around student development and systematic program implementation. The current framework identifies three content areas and an implementation system made up of structural foundation, program components, and program resources.

For SLPS, the three content areas describe what students should gain from the program: academic development, career development, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development. The implementation system describes what adults must build and maintain: a structural foundation, program components, and program resources.

The framework is not a decorative model. It is a management structure. If a school has no annual calendar, no time-on-task review, no advisory process, no role clarity, and no results review, the program is not fully implemented even if individual counselors are working hard.

Framework element	Use in SLPS implementation
Academic development	Course progress, attendance, learning habits, transitions, graduation progress, and intervention planning.
Career development	Career awareness, exploration, ICAP review, postsecondary planning, and transition steps.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	Self-understanding, relationships, decision-making, resilience, help-seeking, and belonging.
Structural foundation	Mission, vision, facilities, advisory council, staffing, and leadership conditions.
Program components	School counseling curriculum, individual student planning, responsive services, and system support.
Program resources	Human, financial, political, time, data, technology, and community resources needed for implementation.

Fundamental Truths of School Counseling

The DESE manual describes school counseling as a program. This means the work is planned, sequenced, evaluated, and improved over time. A program orientation protects schools from reducing counseling to



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a collection of individual tasks.

The program is developmental and comprehensive. Students receive support before problems emerge, while also receiving responsive help when immediate needs arise.

The program assists all students. Targeted services are essential, but they are part of a larger program that includes schoolwide curriculum and planning for every student.

The program uses a team approach. Counselors do not work in isolation; they coordinate with administrators, teachers, families, and partners while maintaining professional role boundaries.

The program is developed systematically and requires leadership. Planning, data review, time analysis, advisory feedback, and annual reporting are not optional extras. They are the management structure of the program.

Academic Development

Academic development includes the knowledge, skills, and habits students need for school success. In SLPS, this includes support for attendance, engagement, organization, course planning, credit attainment, promotion, graduation, and transition readiness.

Counselors support academic development through classroom lessons, student conferences, planning meetings, intervention coordination, consultation with teachers, and data review.

Academic development work should be documented through calendars, student planning records, intervention lists, credit review records, and annual results summaries.

Career Development

Career development includes career awareness, exploration, planning, and decision-making across the K-12 experience. It begins with broad exposure and becomes more focused as students move toward high school graduation.

At the secondary level, career development connects directly to Individual Career and Academic Plans. Counselors help students connect interests, strengths, course selections, career clusters, postsecondary options, and transition steps.

Career development should be a recurring program element rather than a one-time event. Students need multiple opportunities to revisit goals as they mature and as options become more concrete.

Intrapersonal and Interpersonal Development

The current Missouri framework uses intrapersonal and interpersonal development to describe student growth in self-understanding, relationships, decision-making, emotional awareness, resilience, and responsible behavior.



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This language updates older personal and social terminology while preserving the same core concern: students need skills that help them understand themselves, work with others, handle stress, and make responsible choices.

Counselors support this area through lessons, small groups, individual counseling, consultation, family communication, and coordination with other student support professionals.



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SECTION III

Structural Foundation

Mission, vision, facilities, advisory council, staffing patterns, and program resources.

Structural Foundation

The structural foundation includes mission and vision, program facilities, advisory council, and program staffing. These features determine whether the program has the conditions needed for effective implementation.

SLPS schools should provide private counseling space, appropriate access to student records, a method for confidential family communication, and a schedule that allows counselors to reach students.

A district or school advisory council reviews priorities, data, implementation barriers, and annual results. The council should inform program improvement, not become a symbolic meeting without follow-up.

Program Resources

Program resources include people, time, funding, data, technology, policy, facilities, professional learning, and community partnerships.

The DESE manual identifies staffing as a structural concern because a comprehensive program cannot be delivered if counselor assignments are too large or if non-counseling duties consume the work year.

DESE describes human resources, financial resources, and political resources as necessary supports. Human resources include counselors, administrators, teachers, families, students, community partners, and business or labor partners. Financial resources include budgeted materials, equipment, professional development, and program support. Political resources include board policy, state and federal law, administrative guidelines, ethical standards, and professional association positions.

For SLPS, program resources should be reviewed annually. A school cannot maintain a comprehensive program if it lacks private counseling space, access to student information, a budget for program materials, an advisory process, clerical support where needed, or a staffing pattern that allows direct student services.



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SECTION IV

Program Components

School counseling curriculum, individual planning, responsive services, scheduling support, and system support.

School Counseling Curriculum

The school counseling curriculum is the planned instruction that reaches students through classroom lessons, grade-level activities, advisory sessions, groups, workshops, and schoolwide learning experiences.

Curriculum should not be limited to crisis topics or one-time assemblies. It should be sequenced across grade levels and connected to academic, career, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development.

Examples include lessons on learning habits, goal setting, conflict resolution, career awareness, course selection, graduation requirements, postsecondary planning, decision-making, self-advocacy, and help-seeking.

Counselors should document curriculum delivery through a calendar, lesson title, date, grade or group served, student reach, and any follow-up need.

Individual Student Planning

Individual student planning helps students understand themselves, set goals, make academic decisions, and prepare for transitions. This component becomes more formal as students approach high school and postsecondary planning.

For high school students, individual planning includes credit review, schedule review, graduation status, ICAP review, career pathway discussion, postsecondary planning, financial aid awareness, and senior transition support.

Individual planning should be proactive. Counselors should identify students who need support before schedule errors, credit problems, or transition barriers become harder to resolve.

Each student's Individual Career and Academic Plan should be reviewed at least annually beginning no later than middle school planning and revised when course choices, career interests, graduation status, or postsecondary goals change.

Individual Planning with SchoolLinks

SchoolLinks is the district platform for documenting and supporting college and career readiness planning when assigned for school use. Counselors use SchoolLinks to help students connect interests, goals, course



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planning, career exploration, college search, application steps, and postsecondary transition activities.

SchoolLinks work should be treated as part of individual student planning, not as a separate technology task. Student use should be connected to counseling lessons, ICAP review, grade-level planning milestones, and individual conferences.

At the middle and high school levels, counselors should use available SchoolLinks records to review student progress, identify students who have not completed required planning tasks, and support family conversations about pathways and postsecondary options.

Schools should confirm the current district SchoolLinks requirements each year before publishing completion deadlines or grade-level task lists.

SLPS portal address: <https://app.schoollinks.com/dashboard>

Source note: SLPS Board materials approved a SchoolLinks contract for College and Career Readiness activities for middle and high school students, families, counselors, and CTE teachers. The dashboard portal is the working entry point for authenticated school accounts.

Login and Access

1. Open the SchoolLinks dashboard portal address in Chrome or from the district-approved bookmark.
2. If the dashboard opens, confirm the left navigation and student search are visible before beginning student planning work.
3. If redirected to a sign-in screen, select the district-approved sign-in method. Staff should normally use the SLPS single sign-on method assigned by Technology Services, such as Microsoft or Google, unless district training directs a different method.
4. If prompted to claim an account, use the district email address and follow the account-claim process only for the assigned SLPS account.
5. Do not create a personal or non-district account for student planning work. If the district single sign-on method fails, submit a help request through the local technology support process.

Counselor Use

1. Review assigned student caseloads, grade-level planning tasks, and ICAP completion status.
2. Use interest, career, college, scholarship, application, and postsecondary planning tools during individual conferences, classroom lessons, and family meetings.
3. Identify students who have not completed required planning milestones and schedule follow-up through the school counseling calendar.
4. Use SchoolLinks records as one input for ICAP review, course planning, senior transition checks, and postsecondary readiness conversations.
5. Confirm annual SchoolLinks task lists and completion expectations with district College and Career Readiness leadership before publishing deadlines to students or families.

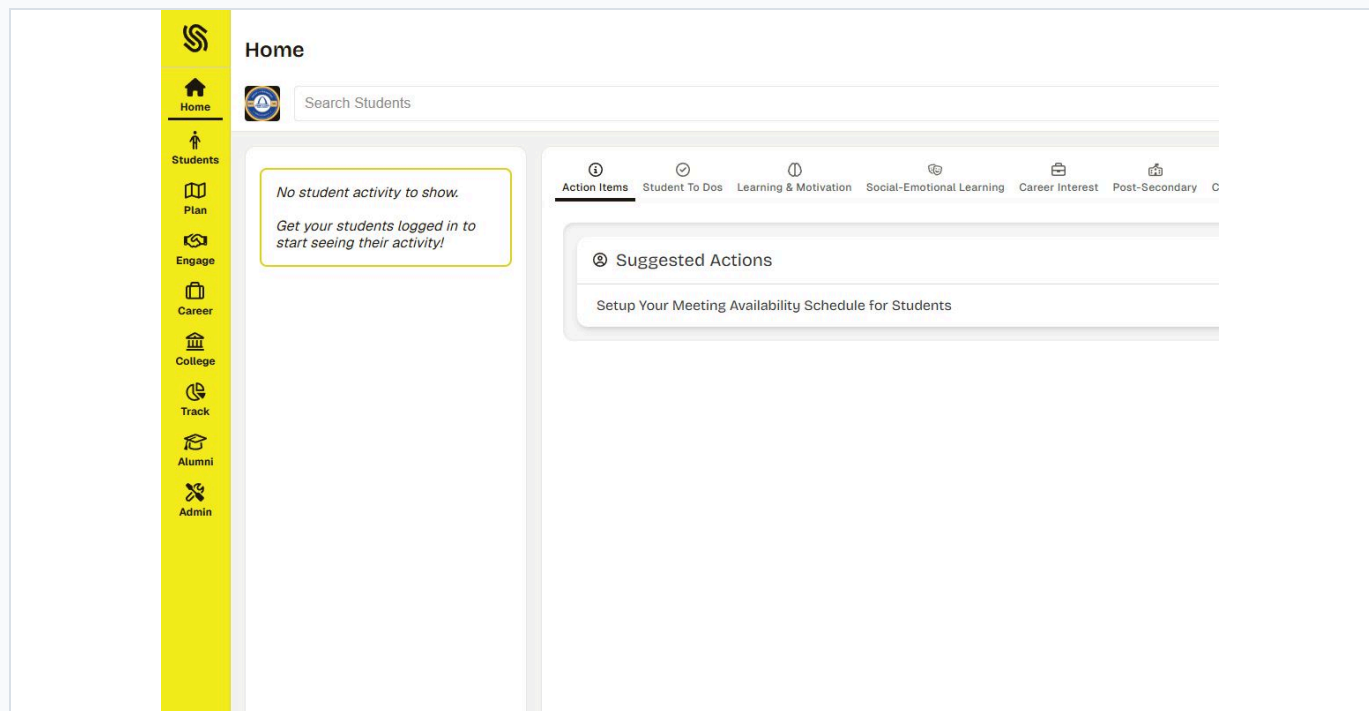


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Documentation Expectations

- Record student conference notes in the district-approved location for counseling documentation.
- Document ICAP or planning completion status according to current district expectations.
- Do not copy sensitive student planning details into informal spreadsheets unless district leadership has approved the storage location.
- Keep family-facing communication consistent with current SLPS College and Career Readiness guidance.



SchoolLinks dashboard portal captured in Chrome on June 29, 2026.

Student ICAP Completion Workflow in SchoolLinks

The student ICAP process in SchoolLinks should be taught as a guided sequence. Counselors should preview the student workflow in Student Demo before classroom lessons, grade-level meetings, or individual conferences. In the demo reviewed for this handbook, student ICAP work appears through the student To Do List and the Plan area, including tasks such as career-learning units, the Find Your Path assessment, Explore Opportunities, Submit Personalized Plans, Submit Course Plan, career experience records, activity records, postsecondary planning units, and financial-aid learning units.

Counselor Setup and Demonstration

1. From the SchoolLinks dashboard, select Student Demo.
2. Choose the school and grade level that match the student group being taught, then select Start Demo.



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3. Use the demo student view to preview the left navigation, including Home, Student, Explore, Plan, Engage, Career, and College.
4. Open the student To Do List and identify the ICAP tasks assigned for that grade level before presenting the lesson to students.
5. Confirm the current grade-level task list with district College and Career Readiness leadership before treating a task as required for ICAP completion.

Student Steps for Completing the ICAP

1. Students log in to SchoolLinks through the district-approved student sign-in route.
2. Students open Home and review the To Do List for assigned ICAP tasks.
3. Students complete assigned career and postsecondary learning units, such as How to Explore Careers, Post Secondary Planning and College Search, Planning for 2-Year Schools, Planning for 4-Year Schools, Planning for the Military, Jobs and Internships, Financial Aid, and other assigned units.
4. Students complete required assessments, including Find Your Path or other assigned interest, strength, career, or learning assessments.
5. Students use Explore, Career, and College tools to favorite careers, majors, training programs, colleges, military options, apprenticeships, employment options, internships, or other pathways that match their interests.
6. Students open Submit Personalized Plans and complete all required plan sections. The plan should connect interests, goals, courses, career pathway thinking, postsecondary options, and next steps.
7. Students add the required digital signature when the personalized plan is complete. If guardian review or signature is configured, students follow the school process for family review.
8. Students open Submit Course Plan and review the planned course sequence with the counselor, including graduation requirements, recovery needs, CTE or advanced-course options, and alignment to the student's ICAP goals.
9. Students record activities, career experiences, internship experiences, work-based learning, service, leadership, or other evidence when those tasks are assigned.
10. Students return to the To Do List and confirm that required ICAP tasks show as complete or submitted.

Counselor Review

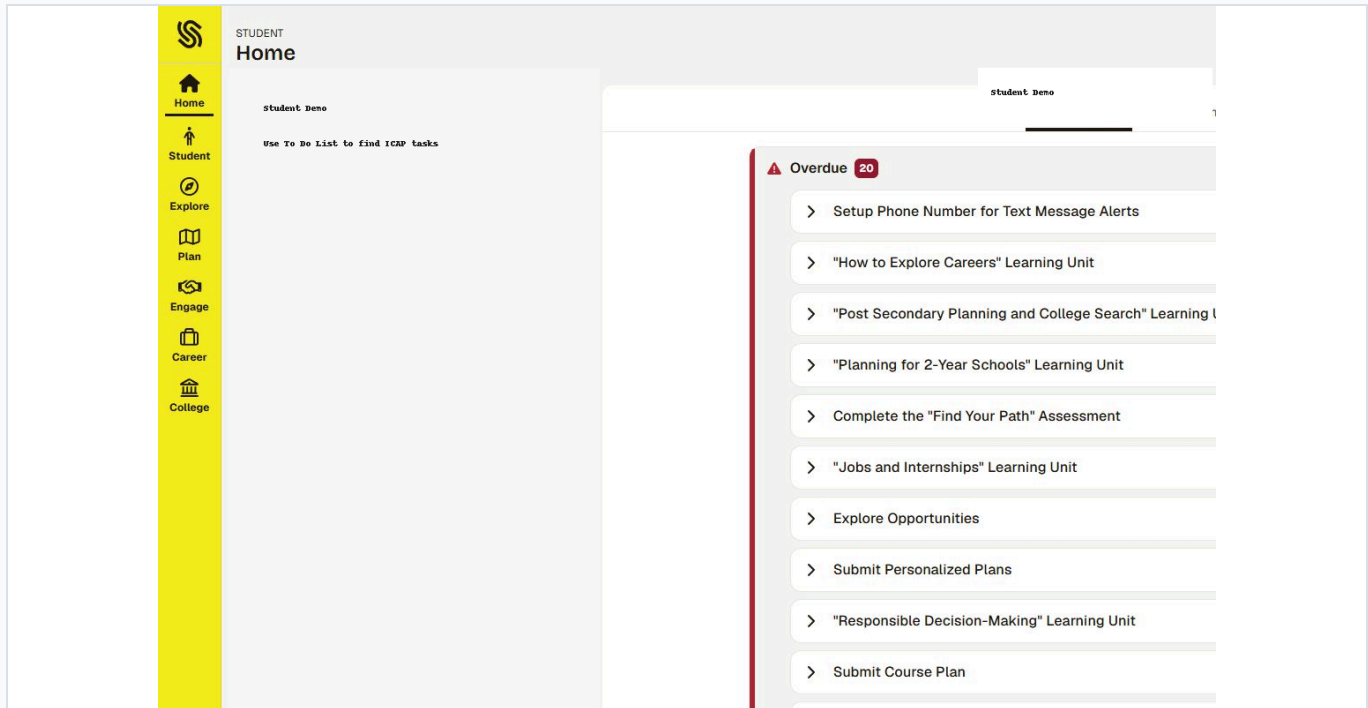
- Review completion status by grade level, school, student group, and assigned counselor caseload.
- Follow up with students who have incomplete personalized plans, missing course plans, unsigned plans, or unfinished grade-level tasks.
- Use individual conferences to connect the SchoolLinks plan to transcript review, graduation status, Focus SIS scheduling, family communication, and postsecondary transition steps.
- Keep the ICAP record in SchoolLinks as the working student planning artifact and document counselor follow-up in the district-approved record location.



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In-app support: The SchoolLinks student demo links to a help article titled "How to complete and submit a Personalized Plan (PGP, IGP, ICAP, etc.) as a student." Staff should use the current in-app help article when platform screens or labels change.



SchoolLinks Student Demo To Do List showing ICAP-related tasks. Demo profile details are redacted.

Responsive Services

Responsive services address immediate concerns that interfere with student learning, safety, attendance, relationships, or well-being. These services may include individual counseling, small-group counseling, consultation, crisis response, family contact, and referral.

Responsive services require professional judgment. Counselors must consider urgency, confidentiality, student safety, mandated reporting, family communication, and coordination with other support staff.

School counseling is not long-term therapy. Brief individual or group counseling generally occurs within three to six sessions for a particular concern. If the concern requires ongoing therapy, intensive case management, medical care, or specialized assessment, the counselor initiates referral and follow-up through district procedure.

Schools must follow current district-approved procedures for crisis response, mandated reporting, suicide risk, threat assessment, and external referrals. Counseling staff should keep the local procedure references current in the annual program file.



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Social Services with CareSolace

CareSolace is used as a referral and connection resource when students or families need support beyond the brief counseling and school-based services available through the comprehensive school counseling program.

Counselors may use CareSolace as part of the referral process for mental health, family support, substance-use, grief, trauma, or other social-service needs when the concern requires outside care or ongoing support.

Use of CareSolace should follow district expectations for consent, confidentiality, mandated reporting, crisis response, and family communication. A referral to CareSolace does not replace required safety protocols or internal escalation when immediate risk is present.

Counselors should document the referral date, general reason for referral, parent or guardian contact when required, follow-up plan, and any school-based supports that continue while outside services are being arranged.

SLPS portal address: <https://caresolace.com/entity-user/dashboard>

Source note: SLPS public school pages describe CareSolace as a complimentary and confidential care-coordination resource that helps match people to mental health or substance-use treatment options.

Login and Access

1. Open the CareSolace dashboard portal address in Chrome or from the district-approved student support resource link.
2. If the dashboard opens, confirm the Dashboard, Warm Handoff, Help Center, Resource Center, and Care Match options are visible.
3. If redirected to sign in, use the district email address or district-approved sign-in method when prompted.
4. If the family-facing referral link is needed, use the current SLPS or school-published CareSolace resource link rather than sending a staff-only login address.
5. If a student or family is in immediate danger, follow SLPS crisis, safety, mandated reporting, and emergency procedures before using CareSolace.

Counselor Use

1. Use CareSolace when a student, family, or staff member needs connection to outside mental health, substance-use, social-service, or care-coordination support.
2. Discuss referral purpose, consent, family contact, confidentiality limits, and follow-up expectations before initiating a referral when the situation allows.
3. Coordinate with the school social worker, administrator, nurse, or other assigned support staff when the referral connects to an active safety, attendance, family, or intervention plan.



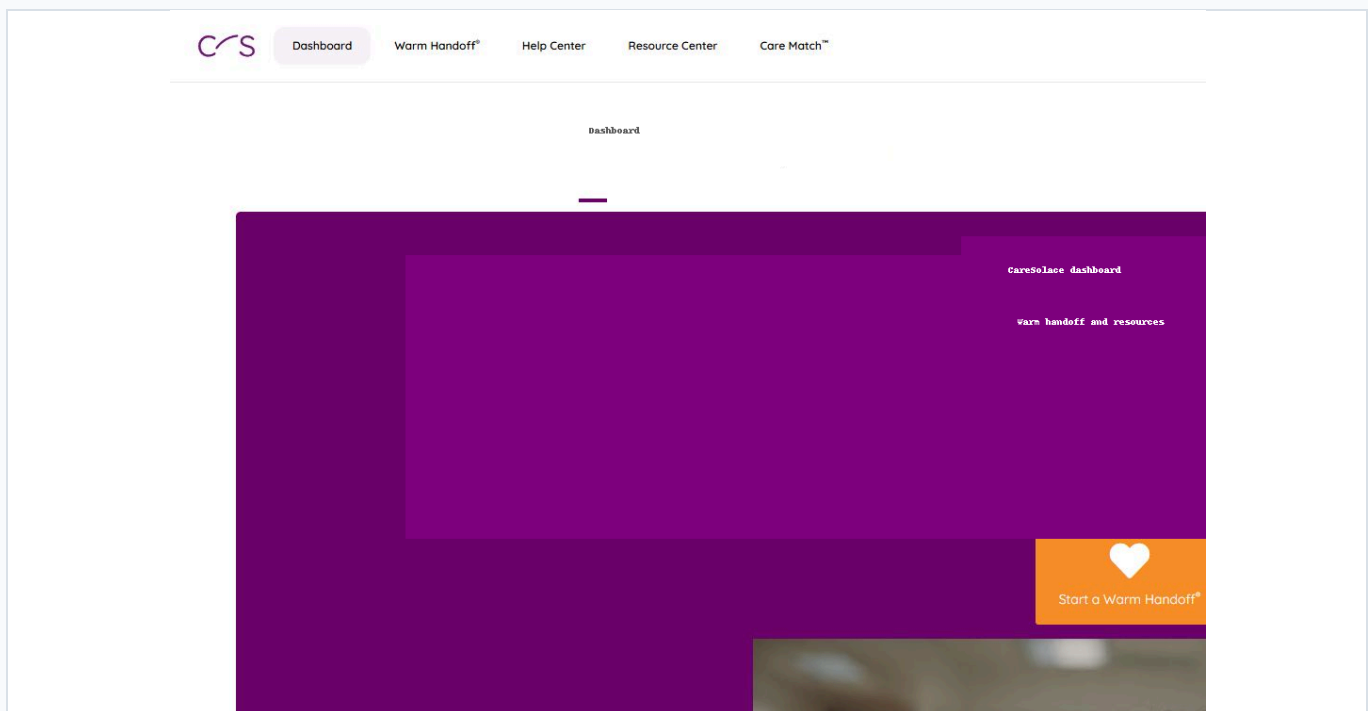
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4. Use CareSolace as an extension of school support, not as a replacement for required SLPS safety, suicide risk, threat assessment, or mandated reporting procedures.

Documentation Expectations

- Document the referral date, general referral reason, parent or guardian contact when required, and planned school follow-up.
- Record only the information needed for school support and required district documentation.
- Track whether the referral connection was completed when that information is available through appropriate follow-up.
- Protect student and family privacy when communicating about outside service needs.



CareSolace dashboard portal captured in Chrome on June 29, 2026. Personal account details are redacted.

Care Solace Referral and Warm Handoff Workflow

Care Solace should be used when a student, family, or staff member needs help connecting to outside care, mental health support, substance-use treatment, or related social-service resources. It is a care-coordination tool, not an emergency response system and not a replacement for SLPS crisis, safety, suicide risk, threat assessment, mandated reporting, or administrator notification procedures.

Before Starting a Referral

1. Determine whether the situation is routine, urgent, or an immediate safety concern.
2. For immediate safety concerns, follow SLPS crisis and emergency procedures first.



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3. Confirm whether parent or guardian contact, student consent, or family consent is required for the referral situation.
4. Gather only the minimum information needed to support the referral, such as student or family contact information, general area of need, language preference, insurance or payment considerations if provided by the family, and preferred contact method.
5. Coordinate with the school social worker, administrator, nurse, or other assigned support staff when the need is connected to an existing support plan.

Using the Dashboard

1. Open the Care Solace dashboard portal.
2. Use Dashboard to orient to the available tools and confirm the account is in the staff-facing workspace.
3. Use Warm Handoff when the school is helping connect a student, family, or staff member to outside care coordination.
4. Use Resource Center or Care Match when looking for provider options or resource information that may support a referral conversation.
5. Use Help Center if the counselor needs current platform directions or support before completing the referral.

Warm Handoff Steps

1. Select Warm Handoff from the dashboard.
2. Enter the required contact and referral fields according to current district expectations.
3. Use general need categories rather than unnecessary clinical detail.
4. Confirm the preferred contact method and any language-access need before submitting.
5. Review the referral information before submission to avoid sending incorrect contact information.
6. Submit only when the family, student, or staff member has been informed according to district procedure and the referral is appropriate for outside care coordination.
7. Document the school follow-up plan so the referral does not replace school-based support while the connection is pending.

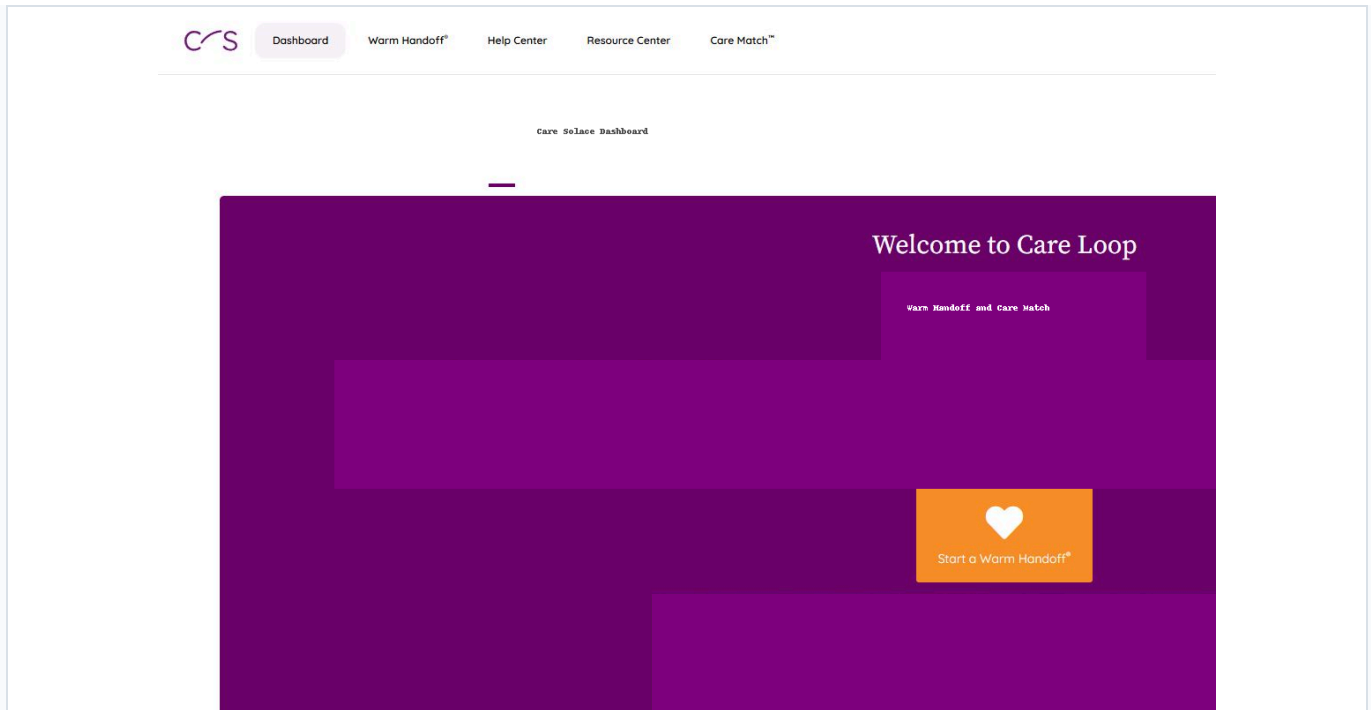
Follow-Up and Documentation

- Record the referral date, general reason, referral route, consent or family contact status when required, and planned school follow-up.
- Do not store detailed clinical notes in informal documents or unsecured files.
- Follow up with the student or family within the school support role to confirm whether additional school-based support is needed.
- Escalate immediately through SLPS procedure if new safety information emerges after the referral.



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Care Solace dashboard showing Dashboard, Warm Handoff, Help Center, Resource Center, and Care Match. Personal details are redacted.

Scheduling with Focus Student Information System

Focus Student Information System is the district student information system used to review and support schedules, course requests, grades, credits, graduation requirements, and other student record information available to counseling staff.

Scheduling support is part of academic development and individual student planning. Counselors use Focus to identify course conflicts, missing credits, incorrect placements, failed courses, recovery needs, transfer-record issues, and senior graduation risks.

Counselors should coordinate schedule changes with the principal, registrar, teachers, and other assigned staff according to local building procedure. Schedule decisions should be documented clearly so that student records, family communication, and graduation planning remain aligned.

Schools should define annual scheduling checkpoints in Focus, including spring course requests, summer review, launch-week schedule corrections, transfer intake, senior credit checks, and closeout review after final grades.

SLPS portal address: <https://slps.focusschoolsoftware.com/focus/>

Source note: The SLPS registration page states that Saint Louis Public Schools uses Focus SIS for its student information system, and the public SLPS site links to the Focus Parent Portal.



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Login and Access

1. Open the SLPS Focus SIS portal address in Chrome or from the district-approved Focus bookmark.
2. If the portal opens, confirm the Select Student/Staff menu and Find a Student panel are visible before beginning student-record work.
3. If redirected to sign in, enter the assigned SLPS Focus username and password or use the current district single sign-on route if configured.
4. Use the Forgot Password link or the district support process if credentials do not work.
5. Access only students and records connected to assigned job responsibilities.

Counselor Use

1. Review current schedules, course requests, grade history, transcript information, credits, graduation requirements, attendance, and other student records available to the counselor role.
2. Identify course conflicts, missing credits, failed courses, transfer-record issues, recovery needs, and senior graduation risks.
3. Coordinate schedule corrections with the principal, registrar, teachers, and other assigned staff according to building procedure.
4. Use Focus checkpoints for spring course requests, summer review, launch-week schedule corrections, transfer intake, senior credit checks, and closeout review after final grades.

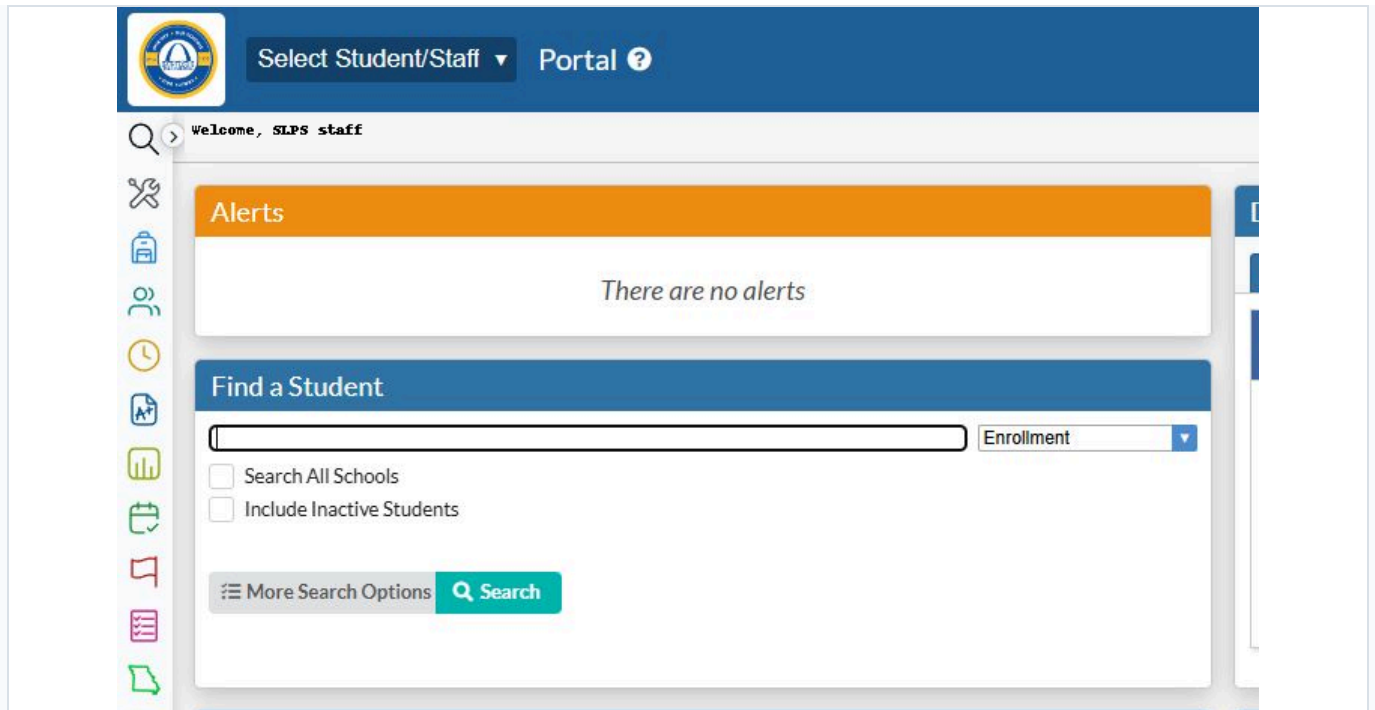
Documentation Expectations

- Document schedule decisions, credit concerns, family contact, and follow-up actions in the district-approved record location.
- Use Focus data as the official student record source when reviewing schedules, credits, and graduation progress.
- Do not export student lists or transcripts to unsecured locations.
- When a record appears incorrect, follow the registrar or district data-correction procedure rather than editing outside the assigned permission level.



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SLPS Focus SIS portal captured in Chrome on June 29, 2026. Personal and student details are redacted.

Focus SIS Student Record and Scheduling Workflow

Focus SIS is the official student information system for schedule review, student records, course requests, grade history, attendance, transcript information, and other data available to the counselor role. Counselors should use Focus SIS as the official source for student-record review and should avoid maintaining duplicate student-record files outside approved district systems.

Find a Student

1. Open the Focus SIS portal.
2. Confirm the Select Student/Staff menu and Find a Student panel are visible.
3. Use the student search field to search by the approved identifier available to the counselor, such as student name or student number.
4. Use Search All Schools only when the counselor has a legitimate work reason and permission to look outside the current school assignment.
5. Use Include Inactive Students only when reviewing withdrawn, transferred, summer, recovery, or historical records for an approved purpose.
6. Select the correct student record before reviewing grades, schedule, requests, or other student information.

Schedule and Course-Planning Review

1. Review the current schedule before making recommendations or changes.



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2. Check course requests, course history, grades, credits, and graduation requirements before approving a schedule adjustment.
3. Compare the proposed schedule change with the student's ICAP, pathway interest, CTE plan, intervention plan, or graduation status.
4. Coordinate with the principal, registrar, teacher, case manager, or other assigned staff when a change affects graduation requirements, special education services, English learner services, athletic eligibility, or program placement.
5. Use local building procedure for schedule-change approval and do not make changes outside assigned permissions.
6. After a schedule change, confirm that the student schedule, family communication, and counseling documentation are aligned.

Common Counselor Uses

- Ninth-grade transition review: verify schedules, credits, supports, and intervention needs.
- Senior review: verify graduation status, missing credits, failed courses, recovery needs, and schedule accuracy.
- Transfer intake: review records, course placement, graduation requirements, and immediate schedule gaps.
- Course request season: compare requests with graduation requirements, pathway interests, and ICAP goals.
- Closeout review: use final grades and credit records to identify summer recovery, schedule corrections, and family communication needs.

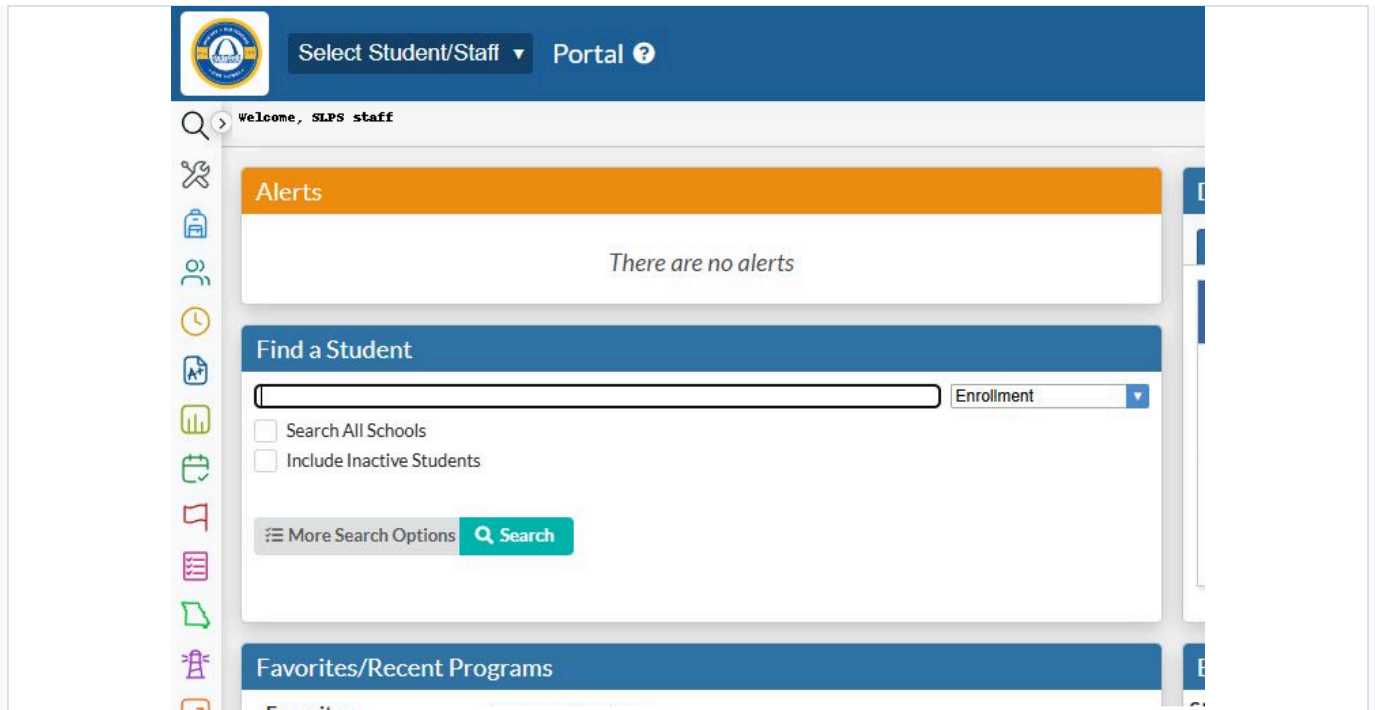
Data Handling and Documentation

- Use Focus SIS as the official record source when reviewing schedule, credit, and graduation information.
- Do not export student lists, schedules, transcripts, or grade records to unsecured locations.
- Document the reason for schedule changes, credit concerns, family contact, and follow-up actions in the district-approved record location.
- If a record appears incorrect, follow the registrar or district data-correction process rather than creating a separate unofficial record.



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Focus SIS portal showing Select Student/Staff and Find a Student workflow. Personal and student details are redacted.

System Support

System support includes the planning, coordination, professional learning, consultation, data analysis, committee work, program management, and community outreach needed to sustain the counseling program.

System support is legitimate counseling work when it strengthens services for students. It becomes a problem when unrelated administrative duties replace direct or indirect services that require counselor expertise.

Principals and counselors should review system support expectations during annual agreement meetings so that counselor time is aligned to the program.

Grade-Level Implementation

The grade-level guidance below applies the Section IV program components across elementary, middle, and high school programs. It describes developmental expectations without creating a separate core manual section.



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Elementary School Program

Elementary school counseling establishes foundations for learning, belonging, self-awareness, emotional regulation, friendship, problem solving, attendance, and early career awareness.

Counselors should provide classroom lessons and small groups that help students build habits before problems become entrenched. They also consult with teachers and families when a student needs additional support.

Elementary planning should include transition support for new students, students changing grade bands, and students who need coordinated academic, behavioral, or social-emotional intervention.

Middle School Program

Middle school counseling supports a period of major academic, social, and identity development. Students need help with belonging, organization, peer relationships, self-advocacy, academic habits, career exploration, and preparation for high school.

Counselors should monitor grades, attendance, behavior, course placement, and transition indicators. Students who show early risk should receive timely planning and follow-up.

Middle school career work should help students explore interests and connect school choices to future options without prematurely narrowing their pathways.

High School Program

High school counseling must connect daily student support with graduation and postsecondary readiness. Counselors review schedules, credits, graduation requirements, ICAPs, interventions, and transition steps.

High school counselors also support family engagement, senior reviews, college and career events, scholarship and financial aid processes, transfer student intake, and coordination for students who are off track.

Some high school counseling work falls before students return and after final grades are posted. The handbook should acknowledge the operational need for structured launch and closeout time.

Transition Points

Transition points require special attention because students and families must navigate new expectations, new records, and new decisions. SLPS should define common transition practices for elementary-to-middle, middle-to-high, transfer entry, and senior exit.

A transition plan should identify the student group, the information to review, the family communication needed, the staff responsible, and the evidence that the transition activity was completed.



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Kindergarten Planning Emphasis

Kindergarten counseling emphasizes school adjustment, feelings vocabulary, friendship, personal safety, classroom routines, and asking trusted adults for help.

Academic development focuses on becoming a learner: listening, following routines, trying again, sharing materials, and participating in classroom community. Career development is introductory and concrete, using family, school, and community helper examples.

Counselors should document classroom lessons, small-group needs, family contacts related to adjustment, and referrals for students who need additional support with attendance, separation, behavior, or peer interaction.

Grade 1 Planning Emphasis

Grade 1 counseling builds on kindergarten by helping students describe feelings, recognize growth, practice friendship skills, and understand personal responsibility in a group. Students are ready for more explicit language about choices and consequences.

Academic development includes work habits, completing tasks, listening to directions, and seeking help. Career development remains broad and connected to interests, responsibilities, and the ways people contribute at home, school, and in the community.

Counselors should watch for students who remain disconnected from peers or who struggle with routines after the first part of the year, and should use small groups or family consultation when classroom lessons are not enough.

Grade 2 Planning Emphasis

Grade 2 counseling deepens self-concept, compromise, safe choices, and respect for individual and group differences. Students can begin to compare different responses to conflict and identify strategies that help preserve relationships.

Academic development emphasizes independence, organization, persistence, and recognizing when help is needed. Career development connects classroom strengths and interests to the wider world of work without narrowing future options.

Documentation should show lessons or groups addressing peer conflict, problem solving, healthy choices, and early academic habits.

Grade 3 Planning Emphasis

Grade 3 counseling emphasizes identity, respectful communication, teasing and bullying prevention, coping skills, and the language students need to describe concerns clearly. This is a key year for moving from basic feeling identification to practical problem-solving.

Academic development should include goal setting, study habits, organization, and self-advocacy. Career development can introduce interests, strengths, and how school subjects connect to future activities.



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Counselors should coordinate with teachers when peer dynamics or academic habits are affecting classroom learning.

Grade 4 Planning Emphasis

Grade 4 counseling focuses on belonging, respect, bullying and harassment prevention, healthy choices, and understanding how individual actions affect a group. Students can handle more direct conversations about responsibility and empathy.

Academic development includes planning for longer assignments, understanding feedback, and building confidence as work becomes more complex. Career development should broaden awareness of different pathways and the skills they require.

Counselors should support classroom lessons and small groups that address peer influence, conflict, confidence, and school engagement.

Grade 5 Planning Emphasis

Grade 5 counseling prepares students for transition. Self-understanding, respecting differences, peer influence, and healthy decision-making remain important, but students also need explicit support for the move to middle school.

Academic development includes organization across subjects, managing increased independence, and understanding how habits affect future placement and readiness. Career development can include structured reflection on interests and strengths.

Counselors should coordinate transition activities, family information, and records review for students needing extra support before middle school entry.

Grade 6 Planning Emphasis

Grade 6 counseling supports entry into middle school. Students need help understanding new schedules, multiple teachers, peer groups, digital behavior, coping strategies, and how to ask for help in a larger setting.

Academic development includes planner use, assignment tracking, attendance habits, and early intervention when grades decline. Career development can introduce career clusters and the idea that interests and skills develop over time.

Counselors should review first-quarter data for attendance, course performance, behavior, and social adjustment so support can begin early.

Grade 7 Planning Emphasis

Grade 7 counseling emphasizes balance, respect, coping strategies, peer influence, and responsible choices. Students are old enough to examine how decisions affect relationships, school progress, and future options.



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Academic development should include self-monitoring, grade repair, organization, and preparation for higher expectations. Career development should move from awareness to exploration using interest inventories, speakers, activities, or pathway discussions.

Counselors should use small groups and consultation when students show repeated conflict, disengagement, attendance concerns, or academic decline.

Grade 8 Planning Emphasis

Grade 8 counseling is a formal transition year. Students need support understanding high school expectations, course options, graduation requirements, career interests, and the importance of starting high school on track.

Academic development includes high school course planning, intervention for students entering high school with gaps, and communication with families about readiness. Career development should connect interests to high school pathways and early ICAP thinking.

Counselors should coordinate transition meetings, family communication, course selection, and handoff information for high school counselors.

Grade 9 Planning Emphasis

Grade 9 counseling focuses on successful high school entry. Ninth grade performance strongly affects graduation trajectory, so counselors should monitor attendance, credits, course failures, engagement, and belonging.

Academic development includes understanding credits, graduation requirements, grade point average, recovery options, and how to seek help. Career development introduces ICAP review and connects course choices to interests and pathways.

Counselors should create early warning lists and coordinate intervention before first-semester problems become yearlong barriers.

Grade 10 Planning Emphasis

Grade 10 counseling helps students consolidate high school habits and begin more intentional planning. Students should review credits, course sequences, career interests, and opportunities such as advanced coursework, CTE, internships, service, or enrichment.

Academic development includes staying on pace for graduation and making course decisions that preserve options. Career development should include deeper exploration and ICAP review.

Counselors should identify students needing credit recovery, schedule adjustment, or additional planning before junior-year decisions narrow options.

Grade 11 Planning Emphasis

Grade 11 counseling is a planning-intensive year. Students need clear guidance on graduation status, postsecondary options, career pathways, applications, financial planning, testing when appropriate, and



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senior-year course choices.

Academic development includes transcript review, credit checks, course rigor, intervention needs, and preparation for senior requirements. Career development should move from exploration toward decision-making and transition steps.

Counselors should include families in planning and maintain lists of students who need targeted follow-up for graduation, postsecondary, or career readiness.

Grade 12 Planning Emphasis

Grade 12 counseling centers on graduation completion and transition. Students need senior credit review, schedule accuracy, recovery plans when needed, postsecondary applications, financial aid information, career steps, military or employment planning, and transition support.

Academic development requires careful monitoring after each grading period. Career development requires concrete next steps, not general encouragement. Intrapersonal/interpersonal development includes independence, help-seeking after high school, stress management, and connection to adult supports.

Counselors should maintain a senior review process, document follow-up for students at risk of not graduating, and coordinate closeout work after final grades are available.

Elementary Curriculum Sequence

The elementary sequence should be written in current Missouri content-area language. Schools may use different lesson titles or materials, but the developmental sequence should remain visible in the annual calendar.

- Kindergarten: feelings identification, friendship behaviors, safe and unsafe situations, classroom routines, and asking adults for help.
- Grade 1: growth and change, naming emotions, friendship and inclusion, personal safety rules, and responsibility for materials and behavior.
- Grade 2: self-concept, compromise, respect for differences, healthy choices, and early problem-solving language.
- Grade 3: identity and strengths, I-messages, teasing and bullying prevention, coping skills, and goal setting.
- Grade 4: belonging, respect in groups, bullying and harassment prevention, peer influence, confidence, and persistence.
- Grade 5: middle school transition, study habits, healthy peer choices, respecting differences, and career interest awareness.

Elementary counselors should deliver these themes through classroom lessons, brief groups, family consultation, teacher collaboration, and transition activities. The sequence should be adjusted when school data show a stronger need in attendance, peer conflict, classroom adjustment, or family support.



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Middle School Curriculum Sequence

The middle school sequence focuses on transition, identity, relationships, organization, coping, and early career exploration. Students need repeated chances to connect personal choices with academic progress and future options.

- Grade 6: middle school adjustment, organization, digital behavior, coping with stress, and career cluster awareness.
- Grade 7: balance and responsibility, relationship quality, negotiation and conflict, academic self-monitoring, and career exploration.
- Grade 8: high school transition, course planning, community belonging, decision-making, and career pathway awareness.

Middle school counselors should use the sequence to connect grade-level lessons, small groups, course planning, family communication, and early-warning data. The sequence should prepare students for high school expectations before course requests are finalized.

High School Curriculum Sequence

The high school sequence moves from adjustment to completion and transition. The curriculum should connect lessons and planning activities to credits, ICAP review, graduation requirements, postsecondary choices, and student well-being.

- Grade 9: high school habits, credits and graduation requirements, belonging, safe choices, and ICAP introduction or review.
- Grade 10: positive self-talk, listening and communication, risk awareness, course sequence review, and career pathway refinement.
- Grade 11: self-assessment, negotiation, postsecondary options, transcript review, and financial planning awareness.
- Grade 12: senior action plan, conflict management, graduation completion, postsecondary transition, wellness, and adult supports.

High school counselors should connect curriculum delivery to individual planning. A lesson on credits, for example, should lead to transcript review and follow-up for students who are not on track. A senior transition lesson should lead to documented next steps for students who still need applications, employment plans, recovery work, or family contact.

Program Management and Evaluation

Program management and evaluation are part of Section IV system support. The practices below describe how schools plan, document, review, and improve the counseling program.



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Annual Administrative Agreement

The annual administrative agreement is the yearly conversation between the counselor and principal about program priorities, role expectations, calendar commitments, data review, and appropriate duties.

The agreement should be completed before or near the start of the school year and revisited when the school schedule or student needs change.

The document should clarify how counseling services will be protected from unrelated administrative assignments and how urgent school needs will be handled without eliminating planned student services.

Advisory Council

An advisory council gives stakeholders a structured way to review counseling program priorities and results. Each secondary school should maintain a building advisory council, and district counseling leadership should convene a district advisory council when cross-school priorities or common tools are under review.

Council membership should represent the school community and may include counselors, administrators, teachers, families, students, district staff, and community partners. Membership should be broad enough to examine student access, family communication, transition needs, and implementation barriers from more than one perspective.

The council should meet at least twice each school year. The fall meeting reviews needs, annual priorities, calendar commitments, and planned evaluation measures. The spring meeting reviews participation, outcomes, barriers, and improvement actions for the next cycle.

Each agenda should include data review, progress on prior action items, implementation barriers, student access concerns, and recommendations. Council notes should identify decisions, recommendations, owners, follow-up dates, and items that need principal or district action.

Program Calendar

The counseling calendar translates the program into time. It should show when curriculum, student planning, responsive services, family engagement, data review, and program management will occur.

A useful calendar has annual, monthly, and weekly layers. The annual calendar identifies major events and transition windows. The monthly calendar organizes delivery. The weekly calendar protects student-facing work and urgent follow-up.

Calendars should be visible enough for principals and staff to understand counselor priorities while still protecting student confidentiality.



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Needs Assessment and Program Planning Survey

A needs assessment helps the school align counseling priorities with student, family, staff, and community needs. It should not replace professional judgment, but it gives the program a stronger evidence base.

At least annually, schools should review student need data and collect stakeholder input when feasible. Useful inputs may include student surveys, family feedback, teacher priorities, attendance, grades, credits, behavior, course enrollment, ICAP completion, and responsive-service patterns.

The planning summary should identify priority needs, the student groups most affected, the program component that will address the need, the calendar window for response, and the evidence that will be reviewed at year end.

Use-of-Time Analysis

Use-of-time analysis helps schools determine whether counselor time is aligned to the comprehensive program. It should distinguish curriculum, individual planning, responsive services, system support, and non-counseling duties.

The goal is improvement, not surveillance. If the analysis shows that counselor time is consumed by duties unrelated to the program, school and district leaders should address role clarity.

DESE recommends that direct services should make up the largest share of counselor time. Curriculum, individual planning, and responsive services together should account for about 80 percent of counselor time, while system support should remain controlled so that student access is not crowded out.

Counselors should complete monthly time-on-task samples for review by central office and school administration. Monthly samples help the district see whether counselor time is being spent on the comprehensive program or pulled into non-counseling duties.

Use-of-time summaries are most helpful when paired with student outcome data and calendar evidence. If a school is consistently outside recommended ranges, the principal and counselor should identify the reason and decide what will change.

Program component	Elementary	Middle	High school	K-12 guide
School counseling curriculum	35-45%	25-35%	15-25%	25-35%
Individual student planning	5-10%	15-25%	25-35%	20-30%
Responsive services	30-40%	30-40%	25-35%	25-35%
System support	10-15%	10-15%	15-20%	10-15%

These ranges are planning guides. A school may vary from them temporarily because of student needs, transition points, or crisis demands, but recurring variation should be reviewed during program evaluation.



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Data Review

Data review should guide program priorities and targeted interventions. Useful data may include attendance, grades, credits, behavior, course enrollment, graduation status, postsecondary milestones, survey responses, and service participation.

Counselors should use data to identify students who need support, evaluate whether services are reaching the intended students, and communicate program results.

Data should be handled responsibly. Student privacy and district record procedures must be followed.

Annual Results Report

The annual results report summarizes what the counseling program delivered, who was reached, what outcomes were reviewed, and what improvement steps are recommended.

A concise report can include priorities, activities, participation, results, barriers, and next steps. The report should be useful for principals, district leaders, advisory councils, and counseling teams.

The report should support continuous improvement rather than serve as a compliance artifact.

The annual report should include process data, perception or feedback data when available, outcome data, equity review, opportunities for improvement, and next actions with owners.

Evaluation element	Required evidence
Implementation review	Calendar evidence, curriculum delivery, individual planning completion, responsive-service trends, advisory council notes, and use-of-time summary.
Process data	Number of students served, lessons delivered, meetings held, plans reviewed, referrals completed, and families reached.
Perception data	Student, family, staff, or advisory feedback about access, usefulness, clarity, and remaining needs.
Outcome data	Attendance, grades, credits, course enrollment, behavior, graduation progress, ICAP milestones, postsecondary milestones, or other local priority indicators.
Equity review	Review of access and outcomes by grade, school, student group, program participation, language need, disability, mobility, and other locally relevant factors.
Improvement plan	Target, baseline, result, opportunity for improvement, action step, owner, timeline, and evidence for follow-up.

Program Calendar Guidance: July

District counseling leadership reviews prior-year results, updates shared tools, confirms professional development needs, and checks whether handbook or procedure changes are needed before schools begin planning.



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High school teams may begin reviewing master schedule concerns, returning student credit status, and known transfer or recovery issues when contract calendars allow the work.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: August

August is a launch month. Counselors confirm schedules, orient new students, update referral paths, communicate counseling services to staff and families, and establish grade-level priorities.

High school counselors should review senior status, ninth-grade schedules, transfer records, and students with immediate credit or placement concerns before problems become embedded in the semester.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: September

September is used to begin core curriculum delivery, complete initial needs scans, and review early attendance, engagement, and grade information.

Counselors should identify students who are not connected to school routines, students with immediate academic risk, and families needing early outreach.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: October

October is a strong month for first data review. Counselors and principals review attendance, grades, behavior, service patterns, and curriculum delivery against the annual plan.

Middle and high school counselors begin or continue course and pathway planning activities tied to the next scheduling cycle.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: November

November counseling work often includes family engagement, intervention review, postsecondary planning, and preparation for end-of-semester academic decisions.



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Counselors should identify students whose grades, credits, or attendance require action before winter break.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: December

December is a semester checkpoint. Counselors review course completion risk, responsive service needs, and students who may need recovery, schedule adjustment, or additional family communication.

High school teams should make sure senior concerns are not waiting until spring to be discovered.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: January

January is a relaunch point. Counselors review first-semester outcomes, update plans, reintroduce services, and adjust the calendar based on what the first semester showed.

Students returning from extended absence, transfer, recovery, or crisis support may need targeted re-entry planning.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: February

February often includes course request work, career planning, transition planning, and continued small-group or responsive service delivery.

Counselors should monitor whether planning activities are reaching students who need additional support rather than only students who respond independently.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: March

March is a key month for transition preparation. Elementary, middle, and high school teams should coordinate handoff information, family communication, and intervention lists.

High schools should review junior planning, senior status, postsecondary tasks, and students still needing recovery or schedule problem-solving.



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Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: April

April counseling work focuses on closing gaps before the year ends. Counselors review graduation risk, promotion concerns, attendance, family engagement, and summer program needs.

Advisory councils or leadership teams should begin reviewing preliminary results and identifying next-year program improvements.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: May

May is a closeout month. Counselors support transition activities, senior completion, final family communication, records notes, and referrals for summer or community support.

The annual results report should begin before staff leave so the program's successes and unfinished work are not lost.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

Program Calendar Guidance: June

June work includes final grade and credit review, senior closeout, summer recovery coordination, data cleanup, and preparation for the next launch cycle where contract calendars allow.

District leadership should review school-level results and use them to plan professional development, staffing discussions, and handbook revisions.

Each school should adapt this guidance to its calendar, grade levels, and student needs while preserving the four program components.

K-12 Counseling and Career Awareness Master Calendar

The master calendar is a communication and management tool. It helps students, staff, families, administrators, and community partners see when counseling curriculum, career awareness, transition activities, planning, responsive services, and system support will occur.



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Window	Converted SLPS calendar emphasis	Examples of activities to schedule	Evidence
August and September	Launch, belonging, transition support, early academic monitoring, and career-planning setup.	Orientation lessons, new-student support, career portfolio setup, eighth-grade plan launch, early senior/credit review, family outreach.	Launch calendar, lesson logs, risk lists, family contacts.
October and November	Academic progress, safety and prevention, attendance review, and intervention planning before semester end.	Prevention lessons, attendance/grade review, intervention team meetings, referral follow-up, family outreach before semester end.	Lesson records, intervention lists, referral follow-up.
December and January	Semester checkpoint, academic recovery, student belonging, and midyear results review.	Course-completion review, senior status check, recovery planning, safety/belonging lessons, midyear calendar adjustment.	Grade/credit review, recovery list, calendar update.
February and March	Career exploration, course planning, family planning communication, and transition preparation.	Career exploration activities, course request lessons, family planning nights, technical education information, transition planning.	Course request records, career reflection, family verification.
April and May	Career planning, academic closeout, personal transition support, final grade preparation, and next-grade transition.	Review of personal plans, transition lessons, senior closeout, summer recovery planning, final family communication.	Transition lists, senior closeout records, summer recovery referrals.
June	Closeout, final records, program evaluation, and preparation for the next school year.	Final credit review, graduation completion check, annual results report, calendar revision, source/tool updates.	Annual results report, closeout list, next-year priorities.

The examples above are implementation options, not required event titles. Schools should use the current district-approved observance, prevention, character education, and career-awareness calendars when naming monthly events. The required practice is predictable monthly counseling and career-awareness work tied to developmental themes, transitions, and program evidence.



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SECTION V

Job Descriptions

Role clarity, staffing, job expectations, evaluation, and professional conduct.

Role of the School Counselor

School counselors are responsible for implementing the comprehensive school counseling program. They support all students through curriculum, individual planning, responsive services, and system support.

Counselors are often the initial point of contact for student concerns, but they are not the only support provider in a school. Effective student support requires role clarity among counselors, social workers, nurses, psychologists, administrators, teachers, and outside partners.

Counselor duties should align with professional preparation and program goals. Duties that do not require counseling expertise should be reviewed when they reduce student access to counseling services.

Staffing and Access

Staffing is a program condition. Counselors cannot deliver a comprehensive program when caseloads, schedules, or additional duties make student access unrealistic.

The Missouri CSCP manual identifies the MSIP 6 minimum standard as one counselor for every 201 to 250 students in grades K-12 and describes one counselor for every 161 to 200 students as the desirable standard. Appropriate counselor-to-student ratios are necessary for full implementation.

Where a school or district has more than one counselor, DESE recommends identifying a lead counselor or director to coordinate planning, design, implementation, evaluation, and enhancement. A reduced caseload is recommended for lead counselors or directors when they are expected to manage the program.

Clerical support is a program resource. When clerical work is assigned to counselors, it reduces the time available for curriculum, planning, responsive services, and consultation. SLPS staffing plans should separate clerical tasks from counseling responsibilities wherever possible.

High school access also includes calendar access. Schedule building, credit review, senior closeout, transfer intake, family communication, and launch planning often occur before or after the regular student calendar. Staffing and contract structures should recognize that work rather than compress it into unpaid or informal time.



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Job Descriptions

Current HR-approved job descriptions should define employment duties, required qualifications, and evaluation expectations. This handbook describes program responsibilities and should be read together with official HR documents.

The handbook may summarize role expectations, but it should not create new employment terms or conflict with current job descriptions, evaluation systems, or negotiated agreements.

Official HR documents control current job descriptions, required qualifications, employment duties, and evaluation expectations.

Performance Evaluation

Counselor evaluation should reflect the work of a comprehensive school counseling program. Evaluation should not reduce counselor effectiveness to clerical completion or unrelated duties.

The Missouri School Counselor Standards provide a professional frame for student development, program implementation, relationships, leadership, advocacy, and ethical conduct.

The evaluation instrument currently used by SLPS controls formal personnel evaluation.

Professional Standards

The Missouri School Counselor Standards describe expectations for student development, program implementation, professional relationships, leadership and advocacy, and ethical and professional conduct.

These standards should inform professional learning, supervision, program review, and evaluation conversations.

The handbook should connect standards to practice without reproducing every standard as a table.

Ethical and Legal Practice

Counselors must follow professional ethical standards, district policy, school procedures, and legal requirements. This includes confidentiality and its limits, mandated reporting, student safety, records, referrals, family communication, and professional boundaries.

Counselors must align practice with current SLPS policy, school procedures, legal guidance, and supervisor direction.

Counselors should consult supervisors when a situation is urgent, complex, or policy-sensitive.



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Professional Ethics Guidelines for School Counselors

Ethical practice is part of daily school counseling work, not a separate compliance topic. Counselors should follow current ASCA, district, state, and legal requirements when specific rules control.

Ethics area	Current handbook expectation	Practice evidence
Confidentiality	Explain confidentiality and its limits in language students and families can understand.	Opening script, family communication, consultation notes when appropriate.
Mandated reporting and safety	Follow current law and district procedure for abuse, neglect, self-harm, threat, harassment, violence, and other safety concerns.	Required report or procedure documentation in approved system.
Student records	Use approved systems, keep records factual, and limit sensitive detail to what is necessary.	Approved record location and concise service documentation.
Boundaries and role clarity	Provide counseling services within the school counselor role and refer needs outside the school role to appropriate supports.	Referral process, consultation record, annual agreement.
Equitable access	Review whether services, planning, courses, and opportunities are reaching all student groups.	Disaggregated participation and outcome review.
Professional competence	Maintain current knowledge of counseling, ethics, DESE CSCP guidance, crisis response, data use, and district procedures.	Professional learning record and implementation evidence.
Collaboration	Consult and collaborate without disclosing more student information than required for support.	Team notes, referral follow-up, family contact.



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SECTION VII

Ethical Standards

Ethical practice expectations and operational guidance for consistent student support.

Student Referral

A referral process should define who may refer, how referrals are submitted, how urgent concerns are routed, and how follow-up is communicated. Staff, students, and families need a path that is clear enough to use without knowing the internal structure of the counseling department.

The counselor or designated support team member reviews the referral for urgency, safety concerns, prior interventions, and the type of response needed. Routine academic or planning referrals can be scheduled. Safety concerns, mandated reporting concerns, or crisis situations move immediately to the current SLPS procedure.

Follow-up should be documented in the approved system. The person who made the referral should receive an appropriate status update when possible, but confidential student information should not be shared beyond a legitimate educational or safety need.

Responsive Counseling

Responsive counseling begins with the student's presenting concern and the counselor's judgment about urgency, scope, and appropriate support. The service may be individual counseling, small-group counseling, consultation, family contact, referral, or coordination with other school support staff.

Short-term, solution-focused support is appropriate when the concern falls within the school counselor's role. When a student needs therapy, intensive case management, medical care, or specialized assessment, the counselor coordinates referral according to district procedure.

Counselors document the reason for contact, service provided, referral or consultation, and follow-up plan. Sensitive details should be recorded only as required by district practice and professional standards.

Crisis and Safety Response

When a concern involves immediate safety, suicide risk, threat of harm, suspected abuse or neglect, or another urgent crisis, the counselor follows current SLPS crisis and safety procedures. The counselor does not treat the handbook as a substitute for the district's required protocol.



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The counselor remains with the student or ensures supervision as appropriate, notifies the required administrator or designated response team, contacts family or external authorities according to procedure, and documents the response in the approved system.

After the immediate response, the counselor participates in re-entry, follow-up, safety planning, referral coordination, and communication with staff who need to know how to support the student.

Mandated Reporting

Mandated reporting responsibilities are governed by law and district procedure. Counselors must act promptly when they have reasonable cause to suspect abuse or neglect and must not delay reporting in order to investigate.

The counselor should follow the current SLPS reporting pathway, document required actions, and coordinate with administration only in ways that do not interfere with the reporting obligation.

Training on mandated reporting should be included in annual professional learning for counselors and should be revisited when district or state guidance changes.

Academic Intervention

Counselors support academic intervention by helping identify students, interpret patterns, coordinate planning, communicate with families, and connect students to supports. Counselors are not the sole owners of academic intervention systems.

Academic intervention begins with data: grades, credits, attendance, assessment, assignment completion, teacher feedback, and prior intervention history. The counselor helps the team determine whether the concern is primarily skill, access, attendance, motivation, course placement, or outside circumstances.

Follow-up should identify the student action, adult owner, timeline, and next review date. Students with repeated failure or credit risk should appear on a recurring monitoring list.

Attendance Support

Attendance concerns often reflect more than refusal to attend. Counselors review patterns, student voice, family context, health factors, transportation barriers, peer concerns, academic frustration, and school belonging.

The counselor collaborates with the attendance team, administrator, family, and support staff to identify the barrier and match the response. Counseling support may include student problem-solving, family contact, referral, transition support, or connection to school activities.

Attendance support should be documented with the concern, contact attempts, student or family response, intervention, and next review date.



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Schedule and Credit Review

Secondary schedule and credit review protects students from preventable barriers to graduation and postsecondary readiness. Counselors review course placement, prerequisites, graduation requirements, failures, recovery options, and student goals.

High school counselors should complete early senior reviews, midyear reviews, and final closeout checks. Students who are not on track need a documented recovery plan and family communication.

Schedule changes should be guided by student need, graduation requirements, program availability, and equity of access. Convenience changes should not displace students with academic or graduation-related needs.

Transfer Student Intake

Transfer students need a timely intake process because delays can create credit loss, schedule errors, and disengagement. The process should include transcript or records review, grade placement, course selection, graduation status for secondary students, and immediate support needs.

Counselors should orient the student to school expectations and identify whether the student needs language support, special education coordination, McKinney-Vento support, foster care coordination, health follow-up, or social-emotional support.

Family communication should explain placement decisions, missing records, next steps, and who to contact with questions.

Family Engagement

Family engagement should be planned, respectful, and tied to student needs. Families need understandable information about counseling services, course planning, graduation requirements, interventions, transition events, and postsecondary steps.

Counselors should use district-approved interpretation and translation supports when needed. Students should not be used as interpreters for sensitive planning, crisis, discipline, or counseling conversations.

Family contact records should include the reason for contact, method, outcome, and follow-up while avoiding unnecessary sensitive detail.

Community Partnerships

Community partnerships can strengthen the school counseling program by expanding career exposure, mental health referral options, mentoring, postsecondary planning, family support, and resource access.

A partnership should have a clear purpose, contact person, referral process, confidentiality expectations, and method for reviewing usefulness. Informal relationships are helpful, but a program needs reliable



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procedures.

Counselors should maintain a current resource list and should review it annually for accuracy, accessibility, and alignment with student needs.

Records and Confidentiality

Counseling documentation should be factual, concise, and stored in district-approved systems. Counselors should distinguish between educational records, service logs, personal working notes, and records required by specific procedures.

Confidentiality should be explained to students in developmentally appropriate language, including its limits when safety, abuse, legal requirements, or legitimate educational interests are involved.

Records should be shared only according to district policy, law, and professional standards.

Program Communication

Counseling program communication should help students, families, and staff understand available services, annual priorities, planning milestones, events, and results. Communication should be routine rather than only reactive.

Examples include counseling calendars, grade-level planning notices, family nights, newsletters, school website updates, advisory council summaries, and annual results highlights.

Communication should describe the program without disclosing confidential student information.

Controlled Procedure Reference

Each school should keep a current procedure reference in the annual counseling program file. The reference should identify where the current district procedure is housed, who maintains it, and how counselors confirm they are using the current version.



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Procedure area	Minimum local reference
Crisis response	Current district crisis procedure, building crisis contact, response sequence, documentation location, and follow-up owner.
Suicide risk	Current suicide-risk protocol, notification requirements, supervision contact, re-entry process, and record location.
Threat assessment	Current threat-assessment procedure, team contact, administrator contact, documentation location, and follow-up owner.
Mandated reporting	Current mandated-reporting guidance, reporting contacts, documentation expectations, and supervisor consultation route.
Student records	Approved systems for service logs, education records, working notes, intervention records, and record requests.
Translation and interpretation	Approved interpretation and translation process for sensitive counseling, planning, crisis, discipline, and family communication.
External referrals	Referral-source list, family communication expectations, consent considerations, follow-up process, and annual resource-list owner.
Community resources	Resource-list owner, review date, service categories, eligibility notes, access barriers, and emergency contact limitations.

School Counseling Facilities

A comprehensive program requires space that supports confidentiality, access, and program delivery. Each school should maintain a counseling area that allows private individual conferences, small-group work, family meetings, record review, and access to materials without turning counseling into a hallway service.

The counseling area should be easy for students to find and appropriate for families to visit. Private space is especially important for responsive services, planning conversations, and situations involving personal or family concerns.

When facilities are inadequate, the counselor and principal should identify interim solutions and include the limitation in program review. Lack of space is not a cosmetic issue; it affects confidentiality, student access, and professional practice.

Program Budget and Materials

The DESE framework treats financial resources as part of program implementation. A school counseling program needs materials, technology, family communication resources, career information, professional development, and supplies for lessons, groups, and events.

The counseling budget should be visible in the school's planning process and should not be hidden inside unrelated budgets. A program without a budget depends on informal workarounds and is less likely to be



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consistent across schools.

Budget requests should be tied to program priorities. For example, a school emphasizing ninth-grade transition may need family-night materials, student planners, career exploration tools, or translation support.

Political and Policy Resources

Political resources include board policy, state and federal law, district administrative guidance, ethical standards, and professional association positions. These resources define what counselors may do, must do, and should avoid.

School counseling practice occurs inside a public school system governed by board policy, state and federal law, district administrative guidance, ethical standards, and professional association positions.

Counselors should know where current SLPS policies are housed and should consult supervisors when a situation involves student rights, records, reporting, safety, discipline, disability, or family access.

Advisory Council Operations

An advisory council is most useful when it reviews real information and produces follow-up. The council should not be a once-a-year presentation where adults simply hear what the counseling department already decided.

A strong agenda includes student need data, a review of program priorities, implementation barriers, stakeholder feedback, and recommended next steps. The council should include people who see the program from different angles, including students and families when appropriate.

Minutes should identify the topic discussed, the recommendation made, who will act, and when the item will return for review. Without follow-up, the advisory council becomes symbolic rather than functional.

Program Advocacy

Program advocacy means helping stakeholders understand what the school counseling program does, why it matters, and what results it is producing. It is different from self-promotion. The focus is student access and program improvement.

Counselors advocate by sharing calendars, explaining services, reporting participation and outcome data, educating staff about the counselor role, and showing how the program supports school goals.

The advisory council, annual results report, family communication, and principal meetings should all reinforce a clear message: school counseling is a structured educational program that supports all students.



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Fair-Share Duties

DESE recognizes that counselors may participate in school-related responsibilities consistent with expectations for all certified staff. The key is fairness and proportionality. Counselors should not be assigned more general duty than other certified staff in a way that prevents program implementation.

Fair-share duties should be reviewed in the annual agreement. A brief shared duty may be reasonable; a daily assignment that blocks student access or eliminates planned services should be reconsidered.

When duty assignments are unavoidable, the counselor and principal should identify what counseling activity is displaced and how it will be rescheduled.

Full Implementation and Duty Protection

The SLPS program aims for full implementation of the comprehensive school counseling program. Counselor time should be devoted to the implementation, delivery, management, evaluation, and enhancement of the program.

Non-counseling activities should be reassigned or reviewed when they prevent students from receiving curriculum, individual planning, responsive services, or system support. This is especially important when a recurring assignment removes the counselor from student access every day or during major planning windows.

The annual agreement should identify fair-share duties, any non-counseling assignments, the counseling service displaced, and the plan for protecting required program delivery.

Classroom Lesson Delivery

Classroom lessons are a primary way to reach all students. They should be planned, developmentally appropriate, connected to the Missouri content areas, and coordinated with the school calendar.

Counselors may teach, co-teach, or support lessons with classroom teachers. The counselor remains responsible for the school counseling purpose of the lesson even when delivery is collaborative.

Lesson documentation should include the topic, grade, date, students reached, content area, and follow-up needs. Lessons should be revised when data or student feedback show that a different approach is needed.

Group Counseling and Structured Groups

Structured groups provide targeted support for students with shared needs. Examples include grief, friendship, attendance, study skills, transition, coping skills, organization, or conflict resolution.

Groups should have a clear purpose, selection criteria, session sequence, family communication when appropriate, and a plan for follow-up. Groups should not become informal pull-out time without goals.



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Counselors should review group outcomes and determine whether students need continued support, referral, classroom strategies, or family consultation.

Individual Appraisal and Planning

Individual appraisal helps students understand academic records, interests, strengths, barriers, and options. It is central to individual student planning and becomes increasingly important in middle and high school.

Counselors help students interpret information without reducing students to scores or labels. A student planning conversation should connect records to choices, supports, and next steps.

Appraisal should include student voice. The student should leave with a clearer understanding of the concern, the goal, and the next action.

Educational and Career Planning

Educational and career planning connects course choices, graduation requirements, interests, strengths, and postsecondary possibilities. It should be recurring, not a one-time meeting.

At the high school level, planning should include ICAP review, transcript review, graduation requirements, recovery needs, career pathway interests, postsecondary options, financial aid awareness, and family communication.

Counselors should maintain a process for students who are undecided, students who have changed goals, and students whose current academic record does not yet match their stated goal.

College and Career Readiness Coordination

Counselors support college and career readiness by helping students and families understand postsecondary options, including college, career and technical education, military service, apprenticeships, certification programs, employment, and community-based opportunities.

Counselors should collaborate with teachers, families, administrators, college and career staff, CTE partners, and community organizations so students receive accurate information and timely planning support.

College and career readiness work may include lessons, individual planning, assessment interpretation, career exploration tools, guest speakers, field trips, internships, job shadowing, summer opportunities, scholarship and financial aid information, dual credit, dual enrollment, A+ information when applicable, and transition planning.



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Career and Technical Education Coordination

Career and technical education is a key partner in the comprehensive school counseling program. CTE coordination should help students connect interests, academic preparation, career clusters, technical programs, and postsecondary options.

The counseling program should maintain a current process for sharing CTE opportunities, career cluster information, program prerequisites, application timelines, transportation or access considerations, and specialized program options.

Counselors should review participation data to identify whether students have equitable access to CTE and career-development opportunities across schools, grade levels, and student groups.

Career and Technical Education Program Menu

The counseling program should maintain a current technical program menu so counselors can connect student planning to concrete options.

The current menu should be organized by career cluster or program category, such as agriculture and natural resources, architecture and construction, business and marketing, communication and media, engineering and manufacturing, health sciences, hospitality and culinary, information technology, transportation, and other district-approved technical pathways.

Because program availability can vary by site and year, the counseling department should verify the current CTE catalog, locations, prerequisites, application deadlines, transportation requirements, and contact persons before each course-planning cycle.

Career Awareness and Exploration Calendar

Career development should be visible across the school year rather than concentrated in a single event. Elementary students need broad awareness, middle school students need exploration, and high school students need preparation and transition planning.

A career calendar may include classroom lessons, career portfolios, guest speakers, career days, college and career fairs, job shadowing, technical program visits, financial aid nights, senior transition checks, and family communication.

Schools should connect career events to student reflection, ICAP review, course planning, or follow-up lists so the activity leads to planning rather than ending as a stand-alone event.

Transitions Between Schools

Transition support is part of individual planning and requires explicit handoff expectations across grade spans and school moves.



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Transition work should include records review, orientation, family communication, course placement, support needs, and early monitoring. The transition is not complete when the student is physically enrolled.

Elementary-to-middle, middle-to-high, transfer entry, and senior exit transitions should each have a defined sequence and owner.

Senior Closeout and Launch Work

High school counseling has two operational pressure points: launch before students return and closeout after final grades. These periods involve schedules, credits, senior status, transfer records, recovery plans, family contact, and intervention lists.

If this work is compressed into the regular student calendar, students may experience schedule errors, delayed interventions, or missed graduation issues. The handbook should recognize this work as part of the comprehensive program.

Schools should define what must be completed before staff return, before students return, after final grades, and before graduation data are finalized.

Consultation with Staff

Consultation allows counselors to support students by working with adults who see the student in classrooms, activities, hallways, and family contexts. Consultation should be purposeful and tied to a student need or program priority.

The counselor may help clarify the concern, identify patterns, suggest support strategies, coordinate a family contact, or connect the student to additional services.

Consultation should not become a substitute for direct student services when the student needs direct support.

Referral to External Services

Some student needs exceed the scope of school counseling. In those cases, the counselor helps the student and family connect with appropriate external support according to district procedure.

Referral does not end the school's responsibility. Counselors should follow up appropriately, coordinate with school staff who need to support the student, and continue school-based services that remain within the counselor role.

Resource lists should be reviewed regularly so counselors are not relying on outdated contact information or unavailable services.



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Referral Criteria and Process

A referral for school counseling or additional support should be considered when symptoms are severe, chronic, long-standing, or interfering significantly with a student's personal, social, academic, or attendance growth.

Referral is also appropriate when there is concern that the student may harm self or others, when school-based interventions have not produced adequate improvement, or when health or medical complications appear to have social-emotional effects.

The referral sequence is: concern arises; referral is submitted through the approved form or system; the counselor reviews objective and subjective information; the counselor determines the appropriate measure with the student and support team as needed; intervention or referral is implemented; progress is monitored; and the referring person receives appropriate follow-up within confidentiality and family privacy rules.

The referral process should remain collaborative with families, administrators, teachers, support staff, and external providers when appropriate. It must also preserve confidentiality and comply with current student-record and privacy requirements.

Student Support Team Coordination

Students with significant academic, attendance, behavior, health, family, or safety concerns may need coordinated review by the school's student support team or equivalent problem-solving team.

The team may include the counselor, social worker, nurse, administrator, family and community specialist, teacher, psychologist, or other staff needed for the concern. Membership should be based on the student need and district procedure.

Team review should identify the concern, data reviewed, intervention or referral decision, responsible owner, family communication, follow-up date, and documentation location. Functional behavior, intervention, safety, and request-for-support forms should be used when required by district procedure.

Referral Contact Log

A referral contact log supports continuity when a student is referred for additional school or external support. The log should be kept in the approved system and protected according to confidentiality and records rules.

A useful log includes date, student, grade, parent or caregiver contact when appropriate, agency or support contact, action taken, follow-up date, and comments limited to what is necessary for continuity.

The log should never become a place for unnecessary personal detail. Sensitive information should be recorded only as required by district practice, legal requirements, and professional standards.



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Culturally Responsive Practice

A comprehensive school counseling program must be responsive to students' cultures, languages, family structures, neighborhoods, identities, and lived experiences. Equity is not an add-on topic; it affects access, trust, interpretation of data, and planning.

Counselors should examine whether certain students are underrepresented in rigorous courses, overrepresented in discipline or failure data, less likely to complete planning milestones, or less connected to school supports.

Family engagement should respect language access, work schedules, transportation, technology access, and prior experiences with school systems.

Underserved Student Populations

SLPS counselors should provide intentional guidance for underserved student populations and connect that commitment to current data practices.

Underserved students may include students experiencing poverty, homelessness, foster care, disability, language barriers, mobility, chronic absenteeism, academic risk, or limited access to postsecondary planning.

The program should identify barriers, not blame students for the effects of barriers. Interventions should be specific, documented, and reviewed for impact.

Program Records and Annual File

Each school should maintain an annual counseling program file. The file should include the annual agreement, calendar, advisory council notes, needs assessment summary, use-of-time summary, program priorities, major activities, and annual results report.

The file creates continuity when staff change and gives principals and district leaders a clearer picture of implementation.

Student-specific records must remain in approved systems and should not be mixed into public program files.

Results Use and Continuous Improvement

Results should lead to action. If data show that students are not completing ICAP milestones, the next plan should change the process. If attendance groups are not improving attendance, the group design should be reconsidered.

Not every outcome will improve immediately. The point is to understand what was tried, who was reached, what changed, and what should happen next.



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The annual results report should identify both successes and barriers. Honest reporting is more useful than a document that only celebrates activity.

Career Resource and CTE Partnership Ecosystem

Counselors should maintain a visible career-resource ecosystem that includes career clusters, college fair partnerships, CTE collaboration, resource-center materials, career days, guest speakers, job shadowing, and technical program information connected to ICAP, course planning, and postsecondary transition.

Resource layer	Converted expectation	Annual verification
College and career partnerships	Maintain relationships with college admissions, career and technical education, military, apprenticeship, workforce, and community partners.	Partner list, contact owner, event calendar, access notes.
College fair and postsecondary exposure	Provide students, especially juniors and seniors, access to college, career, military, apprenticeship, certification, and employment information.	Event record, student participation, follow-up list.
CTE collaboration	Coordinate with CTE staff on program options, prerequisites, applications, transportation, work-based learning, and transition steps.	Revised program menu and application timeline.
Career resource materials	Maintain current counselor guides, student-facing materials, career cluster resources, speaker materials, and family communication templates.	Resource review date and storage location.
Experiential opportunities	Use guest speakers, field trips, career days, job shadowing, internships, job fairs, college majors tours, and specialized program visits when available.	Calendar entry, student reflection, partner confirmation.
Technical program menu	Keep a current menu of available technical programs such as agriculture, biotechnology, construction, health occupations, hospitality, aviation, multimedia, electronics, drafting, and engineering.	Verified site availability, prerequisites, application deadlines, transportation needs.
Equity review	Review whether students across schools and student groups have access to career and technical opportunities.	Participation data and action steps.

Curriculum Scope and Sequence Guidance

The school counseling curriculum should be planned as a sequence rather than a collection of isolated lessons. Each grade level should receive instruction that builds on earlier learning and prepares students for the next transition. The curriculum should be visible in annual and monthly calendars, but it should also be flexible enough to respond to emerging student needs.

A scope and sequence does not require every school to deliver identical lessons on identical dates. It does require common priorities, shared language, and evidence that students are receiving planned instruction across the three Missouri content areas.



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Strand and Big Idea Crosswalk

The curriculum sequence should use current Missouri terminology while ensuring that lessons and planning activities address the full range of student development.

Current Missouri content area	Big Idea	Student learning focus
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	Understanding self and identity in community	Self-concept, strengths, emotions, personal roles, belonging, citizenship, and contribution to school and community.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	Interacting with others respectfully	Quality relationships, respect for individual and group differences, communication, cooperation, conflict resolution, and personal responsibility.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	Applying personal safety and coping skills	Safe and healthy choices, help-seeking, coping with expected and unexpected change, refusal skills, and advocacy for self and others.
Academic development	Applying skills for educational achievement	Learning habits, study skills, organization, test preparation, self-management, goal setting, and use of academic assistance.
Academic development	Transitioning between educational levels	Understanding expectations, preparing for grade-band changes, adjusting to new school structures, and using transition supports.
Academic development	Developing and monitoring educational plans	Setting goals, reviewing progress, using information and assistance, revising plans, and connecting course choices to graduation readiness.
Career development	Exploring and planning life career goals	Career awareness, career clusters, personal interests, dignity of work, balanced life roles, and career planning.
Career development	Using career and postsecondary information	Credible information sources, education and training options, career requirements, financial planning, and self-advocacy.
Career development	Applying employment readiness skills	Responsibility, dependability, punctuality, integrity, teamwork, communication, and workplace readiness.

Legacy Standards Continuity and Current Missouri Alignment

The prior SLPS manual organized student outcomes with personal and social, academic, and career-development codes. The current handbook uses the Missouri content areas of academic development, career development, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development. The table below preserves the substantive sequence while updating the language used in local planning.



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Legacy code	Current content area	K-2 continuity	3-5 continuity	6-8 continuity	9-12 continuity
PS 1	Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	Identify feelings, family and school roles, and character traits.	Describe strengths, growth areas, personal roles, and contribution to classroom and school community.	Use self-knowledge, personal planning, and community participation to support a positive self-concept.	Maintain a positive self-concept while balancing family, school, work, and community responsibilities.
PS 2	Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	Demonstrate friendship skills, respect similarities and differences, and identify feelings of others.	Build quality relationships, respect diverse groups, and resolve conflict responsibly.	Practice interpersonal skills, respect individual and group differences, and accept responsibility in conflict.	Use interpersonal, cultural, and advocacy skills to maintain quality relationships and respect others.
PS 3	Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	Identify safe and healthy choices, unsafe situations, trusted adults, and coping with change.	Use problem-solving, decision-making, refusal skills, safety strategies, and coping skills.	Apply safe-choice, refusal, personal safety, and coping strategies in social situations.	Analyze personal decisions, use safety resources, advocate for safety, and manage life-changing events.
AD 4	Academic development	Follow routines, complete tasks, build work habits, and ask for help.	Practice study skills, time management, organization, and accurate task completion.	Use study strategies, test-taking strategies, academic resources, and self-management systems.	Use educational skills and self-management systems to progress toward graduation and lifelong learning goals.
AD 5	Academic development	Recognize changing school expectations and develop strategies for meeting them.	Apply strategies for increased school responsibilities and middle school transition.	Prepare for transition to high school through academic expectations, information, and skill development.	Use transition skills for high school adjustment, senior-year preparation, and postsecondary options.
AD 6	Academic development	Identify learner skills and begin using simple academic goals.	Use goal-setting and self-assessment to understand educational planning.	Use goal setting and academic review to design and refine a four- to six-year plan.	Monitor, revise, and implement educational plans connected to career and postsecondary goals.
CD 7	Career development	Identify interests, strengths, community workers, and the value of work.	Connect interests and strengths to local and global workers and career paths.	Use interests, strengths, limitations, and career-path language for exploration and planning.	Use self-knowledge and career information to refine short- and long-term postsecondary plans.



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Legacy code	Current content area	K-2 continuity	3-5 continuity	6-8 continuity	9-12 continuity
CD 8	Career development	Identify roles, responsibilities, and skills used by workers in family, school, and community.	Gather and compare information about careers, training, education, and work requirements.	Use career and educational information resources to explore career paths and postsecondary options.	Synthesize career, education, entrance, and training information for postsecondary decision-making.
CD 9	Career development	Recognize personal, ethical, cooperative, and classroom helper skills.	Develop portfolio, responsibility, teamwork, and employability skills.	Develop job-seeking skills, interview skills, applications, portfolios, and work-habit reflection.	Use employment readiness, teamwork, responsibility, punctuality, integrity, and communication skills.

Schools should not treat these legacy codes as a separate reporting system. They are retained here to make sure the full developmental sequence remains visible while schools plan with current Missouri terminology.

K-12 Scope and Sequence Matrix

The scope and sequence should organize personal development, academic development, and career development across grade levels using current Missouri content areas and current counseling language.



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Grade	Academic development	Career development	Intrapersonal and interpersonal development
Kindergarten	Classroom routines, listening, participation, help-seeking, and becoming a learner.	Community helpers, interests, responsibilities, and the idea that people contribute through work.	Feelings vocabulary, friendship, safety rules, trusted adults, and school belonging.
Grade 1	Task completion, following directions, persistence, and asking for help.	Interests, strengths, classroom jobs, family roles, and community roles.	Respect, sharing, responsible choices, friendship repair, and understanding consequences.
Grade 2	Independent work habits, organization, effort, and recognizing when support is needed.	Broad career awareness and the connection between school skills and future activities.	Compromise, conflict resolution, safe choices, empathy, and respect for differences.
Grade 3	Goal setting, study habits, organization, and using feedback.	Interests, strengths, school subjects, and career awareness activities.	Self-concept, bullying prevention, coping skills, respectful communication, and help-seeking.
Grade 4	Planning longer assignments, academic confidence, attendance habits, and use of support.	Career clusters, skill requirements, guest speakers, and how work supports communities.	Belonging, peer influence, personal responsibility, empathy, and healthy choices.
Grade 5	Transition preparation, organization across subjects, academic responsibility, and middle school readiness.	Interest reflection, strengths, broad pathway awareness, and transition-related planning.	Self-advocacy, respectful relationships, peer pressure, safety, and preparing for school change.
Grade 6	Managing multiple teachers, schedules, assignments, grades, and support systems.	Career exploration, interests, strengths, and early pathway language.	Belonging, digital behavior, emotional regulation, help-seeking, and transition adjustment.
Grade 7	Study strategies, attendance, grade monitoring, goal setting, and intervention follow-up.	Career clusters, labor-market awareness, course connections, and exploratory activities.	Decision-making, peer relationships, conflict resolution, responsible behavior, and resilience.
Grade 8	High school readiness, course-selection preparation, transition planning, and academic risk review.	Career and academic planning, pathway exploration, high school program options, and family communication.	Self-advocacy, healthy relationships, transition coping, and responsible choices.
Grade 9	Graduation requirements, credit monitoring, high school habits, attendance, and schedule review.	ICAP introduction or review, career pathway exploration, and postsecondary option awareness.	Ninth-grade transition, belonging, help-seeking, stress management, and peer decision-making.
Grade 10	Course sequence review, academic intervention, recovery options, and goal revision.	Career pathway refinement, CTE and advanced-course awareness, and planning for junior year.	Self-management, communication, relationship skills, and responsible independence.



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Grade	Academic development	Career development	Intrapersonal and interpersonal development
Grade 11	Senior-year planning, transcript review, readiness checks, and academic intervention.	Postsecondary research, application preparation, testing or credential planning, financial aid awareness, and career fit.	Decision-making, self-advocacy, adult communication, stress management, and support networks.
Grade 12	Graduation status review, closeout checks, final credit recovery, and transition readiness.	Applications, employment, military, apprenticeship, certification, financial aid, and final postsecondary transition steps.	Independence, persistence, help-seeking after graduation, healthy relationships, and transition planning.

Schools may use locally selected lessons, activities, and resources, but each grade should show evidence of planned instruction or planning activities across all three content areas.

Classroom Guidance Visit Standards Matrix

The grade-level visit matrix converts the prior classroom guidance visit artifacts into a current planning format. It retains the expectation that counselor visits are connected to concepts, resources or activities, delivery method, cross-curricular partners, and standards evidence.



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Grade	Concepts	Suggested activities or resources	Delivery and partner structure	Legacy standards continuity
Kindergarten	Feelings, routines, friendship, helper roles, safe adults	All About Me, classroom routines, feelings cards, community-helper read alouds	Classroom lesson with teacher reinforcement	PS1, PS2, PS3, AD4, CD7
Grade 1	Task completion, friendship, respect, school jobs, safe choices	Friendship practice, classroom jobs, completing work steps, community roles	Classroom lesson, small group follow-up	PS1, PS2, PS3, AD4, CD8
Grade 2	Independent work habits, compromise, conflict resolution, broad career awareness	Problem-solving steps, career picture sort, helper interviews, organization practice	Classroom lesson and teacher consultation	PS2, PS3, AD4, CD7, CD9
Grade 3	Goal setting, study habits, self-concept, bullying prevention, career awareness	Goal card, study-skills mini lesson, coping tools, career interest activity	Classroom lesson, family communication when needed	PS1, PS2, PS3, AD4, CD8
Grade 4	Academic confidence, attendance habits, peer influence, career clusters	Attendance reflection, career cluster exploration, guest speaker reflection, peer-choice scenarios	Classroom lesson, career event, advisory	PS2, PS3, AD4, CD7, CD9
Grade 5	Middle school readiness, organization, self-advocacy, pathway awareness	Transition checklist, planner system, interest reflection, middle school question protocol	Classroom lesson, transition meeting, family notice	PS1, PS2, AD5, AD6, CD7
Grade 6	Multiple teachers, schedules, belonging, digital behavior, career clusters	Schedule-management activity, support-map lesson, career-cluster survey, digital citizenship scenario	Advisory/classroom lesson and small group follow-up	PS1, PS2, PS3, AD4, CD7
Grade 7	Study strategies, grade monitoring, decision-making, peer relationships, labor-market awareness	Grade-check routine, decision tree, career information search, peer conflict practice	Advisory lesson, individual follow-up for risk lists	PS2, PS3, AD4, AD6, CD8



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Grade	Concepts	Suggested activities or resources	Delivery and partner structure	Legacy standards continuity
Grade 8	High school transition, course selection, self-advocacy, family communication	High school planning lesson, course request review, family verification, transition reflection	Classroom lesson, individual conference, family night	AD5, AD6, CD7, CD8, PS1
Grade 9	Graduation requirements, credits, belonging, help-seeking, ICAP review	Credit basics lesson, transcript introduction, support-map activity, ICAP update	Classroom lesson and targeted student conference	AD4, AD5, AD6, CD7, PS3
Grade 10	Course sequence, recovery options, CTE awareness, self-management	Course-sequence review, CTE option review, academic intervention conference, pathway reflection	Classroom lesson, individual planning, family contact	AD4, AD6, CD7, CD8, CD9
Grade 11	Senior-year planning, postsecondary research, financial aid awareness, adult communication	Junior planning conference, postsecondary comparison, financial aid overview, senior risk review	Individual conference, family workshop, advisory	AD6, CD7, CD8, CD9, PS2
Grade 12	Graduation closeout, transition steps, applications, employment/military/apprenticeship planning	Senior credit review, postsecondary checklist, FAFSA or next-step support, exit survey	Individual conference, group workshop, family contact	AD6, CD8, CD9, PS1, PS3

Each school may substitute local materials, but the annual program file should show the grade, lesson purpose, student learning outcome, delivery system, partner role, and evidence of student reach.

Curriculum Delivery Strategies

School counseling curriculum may be delivered through classroom lessons, advisory lessons, large-group presentations, structured small groups, interdisciplinary lessons, family workshops, and schoolwide activities. The delivery method should match the student need and the learning outcome.

- Classroom and advisory lessons reach all students and should be scheduled through the annual and monthly calendar.
- Structured groups address shared student needs and should have a defined purpose, session sequence, selection criteria, and follow-up plan.



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- Interdisciplinary lessons allow counselors and teachers to connect academic, career, and intrapersonal/interpersonal skills to classroom learning.
- Family workshops and planning nights should support transitions, course planning, graduation readiness, college and career planning, and access to resources.
- Schoolwide activities should connect to counseling program goals rather than stand alone as isolated events.

Minimum Curriculum Planning Crosswalk

Each school should maintain a curriculum planning crosswalk that connects grade-level lessons to Missouri content areas, local priorities, delivery method, audience, and assessment. This crosswalk may be a companion tool in the annual program file rather than a long lesson packet inside the handbook.

Planning element	Required detail
Grade and audience	Grade level, student group, or targeted population served.
Content area	Academic development, career development, or intrapersonal/interpersonal development.
Lesson or activity objective	Observable student learning or planning outcome.
Delivery method	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, family workshop, individual planning activity, or schoolwide activity.
Timing	Month or school-year window tied to student need, course planning, transition, or intervention cycle.
Assessment or evidence	Exit ticket, participation count, student product, survey, planning record, completion data, or follow-up list.
Follow-up	Students needing individual planning, group support, referral, family contact, or intervention team review.

ICAP and Postsecondary Planning Milestones

Individual Career and Academic Plans should be reviewed annually and revised as students' interests, academic records, course options, and postsecondary goals change. The milestone process should be visible in the school counseling calendar and annual results report.



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Grade band	Minimum milestone	Window	Owner	Evidence
Grades 6-7	Career interest exploration, academic habit review, and early connection between school choices and future options.	Spring or advisory cycle	Middle school counselor	Lesson record, student reflection, or planning note.
Grade 8	High school transition planning, course-selection preparation, and family communication about high school readiness.	Before high school course requests are finalized	Middle school counselor with receiving high school support	Course-planning record and transition follow-up list.
Grade 9	ICAP introduction or review, credit and graduation requirement review, and identification of students needing transition support.	First semester and course-planning window	High school counselor	ICAP record, transcript or credit review, and intervention list.
Grade 10	ICAP review, career pathway refinement, course-sequence review, and review of advanced, CTE, recovery, or enrichment options.	Course-planning window	High school counselor	Reviewed ICAP and course-planning record.
Grade 11	Postsecondary option review, senior-year course planning, testing or credential planning when appropriate, and family communication for students needing follow-up.	Junior planning cycle	High school counselor	Planning record, family contact when needed, and senior risk list.
Grade 12	Graduation status review, postsecondary transition plan, financial aid or employment/military/apprenticeship next steps, and closeout follow-up.	Fall senior review and spring closeout	High school counselor	Senior review record, next-step documentation, and completion follow-up list.

Schools should set annual ICAP completion targets and review completion by grade, school, student group, and priority population. Students missing milestones should appear on a follow-up list with an owner and timeline.

PPS/ICAP Annual Review and Family Verification Procedure

Personal Plan of Study and Individual Career and Academic Plan work should be treated as a documented annual process with parent or caregiver involvement and current ICAP language.



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Step	Revised procedure	Evidence
Early awareness	Elementary students complete interest, strength, and career-awareness activities that prepare them for later ICAP work.	Lesson record, student reflection, portfolio entry, or participation count.
Middle school preparation	Students begin career exploration and portfolio work, including grade 8 transition planning before high school course requests are finalized.	Career exploration record, transition plan, course-planning record.
Annual review	Students review academic progress, interests, goals, course options, and postsecondary possibilities at least annually.	ICAP record, planning note, transcript review, student product.
Family verification	Schools send or share the plan for parent or caregiver review, provide a method for questions, and document agreement, concerns, or request for conference.	Signed or electronic verification, parent agreement/input form, communication log.
Family nights or conferences	High schools should use freshmen, sophomore, junior, or course-planning nights when feasible to review plans and answer questions.	Flyer, message script, agenda, attendance, follow-up list.
Senior review	High schools complete fall senior review and spring closeout checks for graduation status, recovery needs, applications, financial aid or employment/military/apprenticeship steps.	Senior review log, transcript/credit evaluation, family contact when needed.
Contact documentation	Parent and caregiver contacts should be documented in the approved student information or contact-log system.	SIS or approved contact log, follow-up owner and date.

Students whose families do not respond still need plan review and follow-up. The process should not delay course selection or graduation intervention while waiting for a signature.

Career Platform Completion Standards and Grade-Level Task Matrix

The district-approved career platform should support grade-level career-development tasks without making the handbook dependent on any single vendor. Counseling leadership should identify the current approved platform before each school year, and schools should document completion evidence in the annual program file.



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Grade band	Career-development task	Current platform expectation	Completion evidence
K-2	Career awareness through interests, community helpers, occupations, and school skills.	Use age-appropriate career awareness lessons or approved elementary resources.	Participation record and student reflection or product.
3-4	Career exploration through clusters, occupations, training/education awareness, and community connections.	Use the current district-approved career exploration tool or counselor-selected resource.	Career activity completion and reflection.
Grade 5	Portfolio development, strengths/interests reflection, employability skills, volunteerism, and transition awareness.	Use the current platform or controlled local portfolio process.	Portfolio entry, transition reflection, completion checklist.
Grades 6-7	Career cluster exploration, interest inventory, education/career information search, and preliminary planning.	Use the current platform with counselor review or documented equivalent.	Platform completion report, lesson product, or counselor note.
Grade 8	High school transition planning, course request connection, and family communication.	Use the current platform, ICAP tool, and high school course-planning system.	ICAP update, course-planning record, family verification when available.
Grades 9-10	ICAP update, career pathway refinement, CTE and advanced-course awareness, and postsecondary option exposure.	Use the current platform plus transcript/course planning review.	ICAP record, pathway reflection, course sequence review.
Grades 11-12	Postsecondary research, applications or employment/military/apprenticeship steps, financial aid awareness, and transition next steps.	Use the current platform, college/career systems, and counselor senior review process.	Senior review, application/next-step evidence, transition checklist.

Completion standards should be reviewed by grade, school, student group, and priority population so the district can identify access gaps rather than simply count platform logins.

Elementary Academic Development

Students learn classroom routines, listening skills, goal setting, help-seeking, persistence, organization, and attendance habits.

Counselors help students connect effort, practice, and support-seeking to school success. Lessons should use examples children can recognize and practice immediately.

Counselors consult with teachers and families when students need additional support with learning behaviors, attendance, or adjustment to school expectations.



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Elementary Career Development

Students are introduced to the idea that people use interests, strengths, learning, and responsibility in many kinds of work.

Career learning at this level should be broad and exploratory. It should not sort students into narrow pathways.

Activities may include career awareness lessons, guest speakers, interest inventories designed for young students, and classroom discussions about community roles.

Elementary Intrapersonal And Interpersonal Development

Students practice naming feelings, understanding personal strengths, resolving conflict, asking for help, and treating others with respect.

Lessons should connect directly to school routines, friendship, classroom community, and safe decision-making.

Small groups may support grief, family change, friendship, self-control, confidence, attendance, or adjustment concerns when needs are identified.

Middle Academic Development

Students learn to manage multiple teachers, assignments, grades, and expectations. Counselors help students build organization, study habits, self-advocacy, and transition readiness.

Course planning becomes more visible. Counselors should help students and families understand how middle school decisions connect to high school readiness.

Data reviews should identify students with repeated course failure, chronic absenteeism, or behavior concerns before high school transition.

Middle Career Development

Students explore interests, strengths, career clusters, and the relationship between school and future options.

Counselors should provide experiences that broaden student awareness and help students begin connecting choices to goals.

Career exploration should include reflection and family communication, especially near transition to high school course planning.



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Middle Intrapersonal And Interpersonal Development

Students need support with identity, belonging, peer relationships, responsible decision-making, digital behavior, emotional regulation, and help-seeking.

Counselors should use classroom lessons, groups, consultation, and responsive services to address developmental needs and emerging barriers.

Programs should intentionally support students who are new to the school, disconnected from peers, or showing early warning signs.

High Academic Development

Students need routine review of credits, course sequences, graduation requirements, intervention options, attendance, and academic risk.

Counselors should identify students needing credit recovery, schedule correction, summer programming, or targeted support before the end of the term.

Academic planning should include students and families, especially when graduation status or postsecondary options are affected.

High Career Development

Students refine Individual Career and Academic Plans, explore career pathways, prepare for postsecondary transitions, and connect coursework to future goals.

Counselors help students understand college, career, military, apprenticeship, certification, and employment options.

Career development should include concrete milestones such as applications, financial aid awareness, test registration when appropriate, credential opportunities, and transition planning.

High Intrapersonal And Interpersonal Development

Students continue developing decision-making, self-advocacy, resilience, relationship skills, stress management, and help-seeking.

Counselors provide responsive services and coordinate supports when student needs affect safety, attendance, achievement, or transition readiness.

Senior transition planning should include attention to belonging, independence, support networks, and problem-solving beyond high school.



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Recommended Documentation Practices

Documentation should support student care, program continuity, and accountability without creating unnecessary paperwork. The best documentation is concise, timely, factual, and stored in approved district systems.

- Curriculum documentation should identify topic, date, audience, grade, and student reach.
- Individual planning documentation should record the planning concern, decisions made, family contact when relevant, and follow-up need.
- Responsive service documentation should record the presenting concern, service provided, referral or consultation, and follow-up plan while protecting confidentiality.
- System support documentation should connect meetings, data work, and collaboration to program goals or student support.
- Program evaluation documentation should summarize participation, outcomes, barriers, and recommended next steps.

Counselors should use the student information, intervention, and records systems approved by the district for the type of information being documented. Sensitive personal details should be limited to what is required for student support, continuity, and compliance.

Appropriate and Inappropriate Duties

The school counselor is an integral member of the school team, and the specialized counseling role must be protected so students can access the comprehensive program.

Appropriate duties are those that require counseling knowledge, student planning expertise, consultation, program leadership, data interpretation, or direct student support. Inappropriate duties are tasks that can be performed by staff without counseling preparation and that reduce student access to the comprehensive program.

- Appropriate duties include counseling curriculum, individual planning, responsive counseling, consultation, family engagement, referral coordination, transition support, data-informed intervention planning, and program evaluation.
- Duties requiring review include routine test coordination, long-term substitute coverage, master schedule construction without counseling purpose, discipline administration, clerical record entry, and supervision assignments that could be performed by other staff.
- When a school faces an urgent operational need, the principal and counselor should discuss duration, student impact, and how counseling services will be protected.



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Duty area	Counselor-aligned use	Non-counseling assignment to avoid	Review or alternative
Student records	Use records for planning, credit review, intervention, and student support.	Routine clerical record entry, filing, or transcript processing unrelated to counseling decisions.	Assign clerical tasks to appropriate office staff and preserve counselor time for review and planning.
Master schedule	Advise on student course needs, graduation requirements, placement patterns, and equity of access.	Building the master schedule as a clerical or administrative scheduling task without counseling purpose.	Define counselor role before scheduling begins and document counseling-specific responsibilities.
Testing	Use assessment results for planning and student support.	Serving as routine test coordinator when the task can be performed by non-counseling staff.	Assign test coordination outside counseling when possible; protect counseling services during testing windows.
GPA, rank, and eligibility calculations	Interpret results for students and families and support planning.	Routine calculation or clerical verification as the primary owner.	Use registrar, records, or administrative processes for calculations; counselor supports interpretation.
Discipline	Consult on student support, re-entry, conflict resolution, and intervention planning.	Serving as disciplinarian or routine administrator for behavior consequences.	Administrator owns discipline; counselor supports student needs and prevention.
IEP and 504 processes	Support transition planning, self-advocacy, course planning, and counseling-related student needs.	Owning special education evaluation, 504 compliance, or case management outside counselor role.	Follow district special education and 504 procedures; clarify counselor contribution in team meetings.
Student handbook or course guide	Review counseling-relevant content such as graduation requirements, planning timelines, and student support resources.	Owning full handbook or course-guide production as a clerical publication task.	Assign publication ownership to administration or curriculum staff; counselor reviews relevant sections.
Supervision duties	Participate in fair-share duties consistent with certified staff expectations.	Daily or repeated duty that blocks student access or cancels planned counseling services.	Review in annual agreement and reschedule displaced counseling services.

Elementary Counselor Role

The elementary counselor provides developmental curriculum, small groups, brief individual support, family and teacher consultation, referral coordination, and transition assistance.

The role emphasizes prevention and early intervention. Counselors help students build the skills that support classroom learning and healthy relationships.



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Elementary counselors should be involved in data conversations when attendance, behavior, adjustment, or social-emotional needs affect learning.

Middle School Counselor Role

The middle school counselor supports transition, academic habits, belonging, course planning, peer relationships, career exploration, and early identification of risk.

The role requires close coordination with grade-level teams because student needs often appear across academic, attendance, behavior, and social domains at the same time.

Middle school counselors help students and families understand how present decisions affect high school options.

High School Counselor Role

The high school counselor supports graduation readiness, schedule and credit review, ICAP work, postsecondary planning, family communication, and responsive student support.

High school counselors must have enough structured time to complete launch and closeout work tied to schedules, senior status, transfers, intervention lists, and transition planning.

The role requires coordination with administrators, registrars, college and career staff, special education teams, English learner teams, social workers, and community partners.

Lead Counselor Role

A lead counselor supports program consistency, meeting facilitation, counselor onboarding, calendar coordination, data review, and communication with building or district leadership.

When a building has more than one counselor, the principal and district counseling leadership should identify a lead counselor or equivalent coordination role for the school year. The lead role supports coordination; it does not automatically create a supervisory position or change negotiated employment terms.

If the lead counselor is expected to manage substantial program coordination, district leadership should review caseload, release time, and clerical support so coordination duties do not displace direct and indirect services to students.

District Counseling Leadership Role

District counseling leadership supports program framework, professional learning, data review, implementation tools, evaluation alignment, and coordination across schools.



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District leadership should help schools interpret the handbook, resolve role confusion, and use data for program improvement.

This role should also coordinate handbook updates as DESE guidance, district policy, and local needs change.

Evaluation Philosophy

Evaluation should help counselors improve practice and help schools strengthen the program. It should not be limited to counting tasks or reacting to isolated events.

A fair evaluation system recognizes the counselor's direct services, indirect services, program management, ethical practice, collaboration, leadership, and use of data.

The Missouri School Counselor Standards offer a useful professional frame. Personnel evaluation should also align to the evaluation system currently used by SLPS.

Program Evaluation

Program evaluation asks whether the comprehensive school counseling program is implemented, reaching students, and producing useful results.

A program review may consider calendar evidence, lesson delivery, student planning completion, responsive service trends, advisory council feedback, use-of-time data, and outcome indicators.

The purpose is to identify improvements for the next planning cycle.

Personnel Evaluation

Personnel evaluation should focus on professional practice and assigned responsibilities. It should be connected to the counselor role rather than duties unrelated to the comprehensive program.

Evidence may include lesson plans, calendars, student planning processes, consultation records, professional learning, data summaries, and supervisor observations.

Confidential counseling notes should not be used as general evaluation artifacts.

Results Evaluation

Results evaluation examines whether counseling activities contributed to desired student outcomes. It should be realistic about shared responsibility: counselors contribute to outcomes, but they do not control every factor that affects attendance, grades, behavior, or postsecondary completion.

Results should be interpreted alongside service delivery evidence and context.



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A strong results report identifies both successes and barriers.

Counselor Evaluation Criteria

Counselor evaluation should recognize the full scope of comprehensive school counseling practice. The evaluation process should connect observed practice to program responsibilities while respecting confidentiality and district personnel procedures.

Practice standard	Evidence of practice
School counseling curriculum	Plans and delivers curriculum, uses effective instructional strategies, reaches intended students, and encourages staff involvement when collaboration strengthens delivery.
Individual student planning	Guides students and families through educational and career planning, interprets assessment and record information accurately, and supports goal setting and plan revision.
Responsive services	Uses brief counseling, consultation, referral, crisis response, and follow-up appropriately for identified student needs.
System support	Manages calendars, program files, advisory input, data review, professional learning, outreach, and program evaluation in support of the comprehensive program.
Professional communication	Maintains positive, respectful, and useful communication with students, staff, families, and community partners.
Professional responsibilities	Maintains ethical and legal practice, participates in professional growth, uses responsible work habits, and supports culturally responsive and inclusive practice.

Evaluation Criteria Detail

Evaluation criteria should reflect the full scope of performance-based school counselor practice and align to current program language.



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Criterion	Evaluation focus
1	Teaches school counseling curriculum units effectively and uses appropriate instructional strategies.
2	Encourages appropriate staff involvement so curriculum implementation is consistent and connected to student needs.
3	Collaborates with students and families to help students establish goals and use educational and career planning skills.
4	Interprets assessment, transcript, attendance, behavior, and other planning data accurately and presents relevant, unbiased information.
5	Counsels individual students and small groups with identified needs or concerns within the school counselor role.
6	Consults effectively with families, teachers, administrators, support staff, and other relevant individuals.
7	Implements an effective referral process in collaboration with families, administrators, teachers, and school personnel.
8	Provides a comprehensive and balanced school counseling program in collaboration with school staff.
9	Supports other school programs when the work connects to student development, transition, intervention, or counseling program goals.
10	Demonstrates positive interpersonal relationships with students.
11	Demonstrates positive interpersonal relationships with educational staff.
12	Demonstrates positive interpersonal relationships with families, caregivers, and community members.
13	Shows commitment to ongoing professional growth and current professional learning.
14	Maintains professional and responsible work habits.
15	Follows ethical and legal standards and promotes cultural responsiveness, diversity, and inclusivity in practice and relationships.

PROBE/IIR Results Evaluation and Action Plan

Program evaluation should include a clear cycle for results review, implementation evidence, action planning, and summative reflection while staying aligned to current program evaluation and personnel evaluation language.



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Cycle element	Converted expectation	Evidence
Fall review	Review prior-year results, student needs, counselor role expectations, annual agreement, and program goals.	Annual agreement, data summary, advisory agenda.
Action plan	Set a focused improvement target tied to curriculum, planning, responsive services, system support, or access gaps.	Action plan with target, baseline, owner, timeline.
IIR/IPS or current equivalent	Use the district's current evaluation instrument or equivalent to document implementation and professional practice.	Supervisor feedback, observation, implementation evidence.
PROBE results review	Use process, perception, outcome, barrier, and equity evidence to evaluate whether the activity worked.	PROBE results tool or annual results section.
Spring review	Review progress, barriers, student impact, and revisions needed for the next year.	Annual results report, advisory notes, next-year action steps.
Summative evaluation	Personnel evaluation should reflect counseling role expectations and not unrelated clerical duties.	Evaluation artifacts aligned to role and annual agreement.

The evaluation process should distinguish program implementation from personnel evaluation. Both matter, but they answer different questions.



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SECTION VIII

School Board Policy

Policy alignment, implementation planning, transition, evaluation, enhancement, and sustaining a comprehensive program over time.

Planning the Transition to a Comprehensive Program

The DESE manual treats transition as a deliberate process. SLPS should approach implementation the same way. A handbook alone does not change practice unless schools receive time, leadership, tools, and follow-up.

Transition planning should begin with a review of the current counseling program in each school. The review should identify what is already aligned, what is missing, what is inconsistent, and which barriers prevent implementation.

The planning process should include counselors, principals, district counseling leadership, and relevant partners. A school should not wait for perfect conditions before improving the program, but the district should be honest about resource limitations.

Designing the Local Program

Designing the program means translating the Missouri framework into local decisions about services, calendars, staffing, referral systems, advisory councils, data review, and communication.

Each school should define how students will receive curriculum, how individual planning will occur, how responsive services will be handled, and how system support will be managed.

The design should be written clearly enough that a new counselor or principal could understand the program without relying only on informal memory.

Implementing the Program

Implementation begins when the planned program appears in schedules, calendars, meetings, student services, and records. It is not complete simply because a document exists.

Counselors and principals should review the calendar routinely, monitor student access, and adjust when unexpected needs arise.

Implementation should protect both planned services and responsive services. A program that only responds to emergencies is incomplete. A program that ignores urgent student needs is also incomplete.



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Evaluating as an Ongoing Process

Evaluation should occur throughout the year, not only at the end. Counselors should review whether services are being delivered, whether priority students are being reached, and whether program evidence is sufficient.

Evaluation should include implementation data, perception or feedback data, and outcome data when available.

The annual results report should identify what was accomplished, what remains unfinished, and what should change in the next cycle.

Enhancing the Program

Enhancement is the improvement step after evaluation. It may involve revising calendars, shifting curriculum topics, changing referral procedures, improving family communication, requesting resources, or clarifying duties.

Enhancement should be specific. Instead of saying the school will improve communication, the plan should identify what communication will change, who owns it, and when it will be reviewed.

The district should maintain a recurring handbook review cycle so the manual stays aligned with DESE updates, SLPS policy, HR language, technology systems, and student needs.

Professional Development

School counselors need ongoing professional development in program implementation, counseling techniques, ethics, legal requirements, data use, career planning, crisis response, cultural responsiveness, trauma-informed practice, and postsecondary planning.

Professional development should be connected to the annual program priorities and the needs shown in student data.

New counselors should receive mentoring and orientation to the SLPS program model, documentation expectations, referral procedures, and annual planning tools.

Professional Learning and System Support Topics

Ethics, content-area development, and alignment with Missouri school improvement expectations are recurring professional learning needs.

Annual professional learning should include ethics and legal responsibilities, ASCA ethical standards, mandated reporting, confidentiality, student records, crisis response, suicide risk, threat assessment, current DESE CSCP expectations, data use, academic development, career development, intrapersonal and interpersonal development, ICAP implementation, family engagement, and equitable access.



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System support also includes staff and community relations, consultation, advisory council work, committee participation, community outreach, program advocacy, career awareness integration across curriculum, student intervention team participation, and care team coordination.

Students with Disabilities

Students with disabilities must have equitable access to the comprehensive school counseling program. Counseling services should not be limited or replaced because a student receives special education or related services.

School counselors collaborate with special education staff, families, administrators, and other service providers while respecting role boundaries and confidentiality.

Counselors may support transition planning, self-advocacy, career awareness, course planning, postsecondary exploration, and responsive services for students with disabilities. Counseling work with students with disabilities must align with current special education procedures and district policy.

English Learners and Multilingual Families

Students and families who use languages other than English need accessible information about counseling services, course planning, graduation requirements, interventions, and postsecondary options.

Counselors should use district-approved interpretation and translation supports. Students should not be expected to interpret sensitive counseling, discipline, or planning conversations for adults.

Program data should be reviewed to identify whether English learners have equitable access to rigorous coursework, career planning, interventions, and postsecondary information.

Students Experiencing Homelessness, Foster Care, or High Mobility

Highly mobile students may need immediate record review, placement support, transportation coordination, family or caregiver communication, and connection to school-based resources.

Counselors should coordinate with designated district staff and follow current legal and district procedures.

The counseling program should include a transfer and mobility process so students do not lose time while adults determine records, credits, or service needs.

Collaboration with School Support Service Providers

The DESE manual distinguishes school counselors from other school support service providers while recognizing shared work. This distinction is important for SLPS implementation.



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Counselors, social workers, nurses, psychologists, administrators, and outside partners may all support student well-being, but their roles are not interchangeable.

Schools should define how referrals move among support providers, how urgent needs are triaged, how confidentiality is protected, and how follow-up is communicated.

School Counselor and School Social Worker Collaboration

Counselors and social workers often collaborate on attendance, family needs, crisis response, mental health concerns, community referrals, and student support planning.

Role clarity should identify who provides which services, how referrals are made, and how follow-up is communicated.

Counselors remain responsible for the comprehensive school counseling program; social workers bring specialized expertise in social work services, community systems, and family support.

School Counselor and School Psychologist Collaboration

Counselors and school psychologists collaborate around student learning, behavior, evaluation, intervention, crisis response, and support planning.

Counselors should understand when a concern requires school psychologist consultation and should follow district procedures for referral and documentation.

Shared work should not blur responsibilities for evaluation, special education processes, or confidential student support.

School Counselor and Nurse Collaboration

Health needs can affect attendance, learning, behavior, and emotional well-being. Counselors and nurses should communicate within privacy rules when student support requires coordination.

Counselors should refer health-related concerns to the nurse and should coordinate family communication or support planning when appropriate.

Schools should clarify procedures for urgent health and safety concerns.

School Counselor and Administrator Collaboration

Administrators provide the leadership conditions that make comprehensive counseling possible. Counselors provide program expertise and student support perspective.

The principal and counselor should meet routinely to review program priorities, calendars, urgent needs, data, and role concerns.



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Discipline, supervision, testing, and operational duties should be discussed carefully when they interfere with counseling program delivery.

School Counselor and Teacher Collaboration

Teachers often see student needs first. Counselors should maintain clear referral channels and consult with teachers on classroom concerns, student planning, and support strategies.

Collaboration should include follow-up while respecting student confidentiality.

Counselors may support classroom lessons, grade-level teams, intervention meetings, and family conferences when the work connects to program goals.

Manual Maintenance

Manual maintenance is part of Section VIII school board policy alignment and program governance. The guidance below explains how the handbook should be kept current after initial publication.

Board Policy Article Reference

Counselors should understand where school counseling practice sits inside the broader district policy system. This reference should be used as a navigation tool while current policy sources control official language.



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Policy article area	Relevance for school counseling
Philosophy, goals, and objectives	District goals, operating philosophy, and long-range priorities that shape counseling program direction.
Community relations	Family communication, community partnerships, public information, complaints, advisory participation, and use of community resources.
Administration	Job descriptions, organizational responsibilities, councils, committees, and communication channels.
Business and non-instructional operations	Budgeting, purchasing, facilities, transportation, materials, and operational support for program implementation.
Personnel	Recruitment, assignment, evaluation, professional responsibilities, transfer, and other employment-related matters.
Students	Admissions, residency, assignment, records, discipline, access, and other student-status procedures.
Instruction	Curriculum, instructional arrangements, special instruction, guidance, counseling, assessment, and services tied to teaching and learning.
Construction and rehabilitation	Facility planning and modernization issues that may affect confidential counseling space and student access.
Internal board policies and bylaws	Board ethics, policy development, meeting procedures, governance, and the adoption or revision of policy.

Counselors should consult current SLPS policy and district leadership when a practice question involves student records, family access, safety, disability, discipline, program staffing, personnel evaluation, or legal compliance.

Board Policy Objectives and Annual Calendar

The school counseling program is part of the instructional process and should have a written districtwide plan with program philosophy, competencies, services, activities, evaluation procedures, and advisory review.

In current handbook practice, board-policy objectives should be translated into student-development outcomes aligned to academic development, career development, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development. Current board policy controls official wording; this handbook should not reproduce policy text that may change outside the handbook review cycle.

- Academic outcomes: students build learning habits, planning skills, progress-monitoring skills, transition readiness, and graduation or promotion awareness.
- Career outcomes: students explore interests, understand postsecondary options, connect courses to goals, and make informed education and career decisions.
- Intrapersonal and interpersonal outcomes: students strengthen self-understanding, responsible decision-making, relationships, help-seeking, safety awareness, and belonging.



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Each school should develop an annual counseling calendar, secure principal or designee review, and maintain the calendar in the annual program file for district counseling leadership review. Calendar evidence should show curriculum, individual planning, responsive service coordination, system support, family engagement, and major transition activities.

Board Policy Source Requirements for Counseling Practice

Current SLPS policy should always control counseling practice. Counseling leadership should verify policy identifiers, official language, and related objectives during each handbook update cycle.

Source policy element	Converted handbook handling	Current review need
P6164.2 / counseling and guidance program reference	Counseling is treated as part of the instructional program and comprehensive student support system.	Verify current policy number, title, and official language.
P1111.1.1a / publication or public information reference	Counselors use current communication channels and protect confidential student information.	Verify whether this identifier remains active and relevant.
Seven student objectives	Objectives are converted into academic, career, and intrapersonal/interpersonal development outcomes.	Confirm alignment with current board goals and DESE terminology.
Counselor-student ratio language	Staffing and access are treated as program-resource issues requiring annual review.	Confirm current district staffing standards, negotiated terms, and budget assumptions.
Special education service consideration	Students with disabilities and intensive needs are included in access, referral, transition, and support planning.	Confirm current special education and 504 procedures.
Annual calendar approval and submission	Each school maintains an annual counseling calendar reviewed by the principal or designee and available for district review.	Confirm current submission owner, deadline, and storage system.
Legal reference to Missouri school improvement expectations	The program is aligned with Missouri CSCP and district accountability expectations.	Confirm current MSIP and DESE references.

Board Policy and Regulation Integration

The school counseling program operates inside current Board of Education policy, district administrative regulation, state and federal law, and professional ethical standards. The handbook should not copy policy language that may change outside the handbook review cycle.

Current policy or regulation should control definitions of the guidance or counseling program, program philosophy, identified competencies, services, activities, advisory review, evaluation procedure, student records, reporting, disability services, and family access.



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Counseling leadership should maintain a current policy-reference list outside the handbook body and review it during each handbook update cycle.

Appendix Tool Set

The handbook should be paired with a controlled set of local tools. Tools may be maintained as separate forms or templates so live forms can be revised without disrupting the handbook.

- Master counseling calendar template.
- Annual activities and responsibilities log.
- Elementary, middle, and high school program planning templates.
- Transcript or credit review form and log.
- ICAP or postsecondary planning form and family verification process.
- Career-development completion standards or task checklist by grade level.
- Classroom lesson and curriculum delivery log.
- Time-on-task analysis form.
- Senior exit survey or postsecondary transition survey.
- Responsive-service referral form and contact log.
- Student support team referral or request-for-support form.
- Safety, intervention, or behavior support plan templates required by district procedure.
- Ethical and legal practice reference sheet.
- Annual results report template.

Each tool should identify the owner, revision date, storage location, confidentiality level, and required review cycle.



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APPENDIX A

Operational Appendices and Forms

Working forms, logs, and program tools.



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Kindergarten Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	school routines, listening and participation, help-seeking	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	community helpers, interests and responsibilities, work as contribution	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	feelings vocabulary, friendship, personal safety and trusted adults	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 1 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	task completion, following directions, trying again after mistakes	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	family and school roles, classroom jobs, personal interests	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	respect, sharing, responsible choices	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 2 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	independent work habits, organization, asking for support	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	broad career awareness, school skills and future activities, community roles	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	compromise, conflict resolution, safe choices	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 3 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	goal setting, study habits, using feedback	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	strengths and interests, school subjects and work, career awareness	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	self-concept, bullying prevention, coping skills	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 4 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	planning assignments, academic confidence, attendance habits	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	career clusters, skill requirements, guest speakers	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	belonging, peer influence, healthy choices	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 5 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	middle school readiness, organization across subjects, academic responsibility	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	interest reflection, pathway awareness, transition-related planning	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	self-advocacy, respectful relationships, peer pressure	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 6 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	multiple teachers and schedules, assignment tracking, support systems	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	career exploration, interests and strengths, career cluster language	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	belonging, digital behavior, emotional regulation	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 7 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	study strategies, grade monitoring, intervention follow-up	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	career clusters, labor-market awareness, course connections	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	decision-making, peer relationships, resilience	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 8 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	high school readiness, course-selection preparation, academic risk review	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	pathway exploration, high school program options, family communication	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	self-advocacy, transition coping, responsible choices	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 9 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	graduation requirements, credit monitoring, high school habits	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	ICAP update, pathway exploration, postsecondary awareness	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	ninth-grade transition, belonging, help-seeking	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 10 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	course sequence review, academic intervention, recovery options	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	pathway refinement, CTE awareness, advanced-course awareness	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	self-management, communication, responsible independence	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 11 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	senior-year planning, transcript review, readiness checks	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	postsecondary research, application preparation, financial aid awareness	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	adult communication, self-advocacy, support networks	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Grade 12 Detailed Scope and Sequence

This appendix table provides a grade-level concept, activity, delivery, and standards format. Schools should select activities and resources that match local needs while maintaining the developmental focus.

Content area	Concepts	Student outcome	Delivery or activity options	Cross-curricular or partner roles	Evidence
Academic development	graduation status review, closeout checks, final recovery planning	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Career development	applications, employment or military planning, transition steps	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.
Intrapersonal and interpersonal development	independence, persistence, post-graduation help-seeking	Students demonstrate the listed concepts through a lesson product, planning record, reflection, conference note, or follow-up list.	Classroom lesson, advisory lesson, small group, individual planning conference, family night, or coordinated school activity.	Counselor, teacher, administrator, family, college and career staff, CTE partner, support staff, or community partner as appropriate.	Lesson record, participation count, student product, ICAP note, contact log, referral record, or annual results summary.



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Master Counseling Calendar Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Month	Program component	Activity or service	Grade or audience	Owner	Partner staff	Evidence	Follow-up needed
August	Curriculum	Transition and school-belonging lessons	All grades	Counselor	Teachers and administrators	Lesson log and participation count	Students needing individual support
September	Individual planning	Academic and attendance risk review	Priority students	Counselor	Intervention team	Risk list and conference notes	Family contacts and intervention plans
Spring	Program evaluation	Annual results review and next-year priorities	School program	Counselor	Principal and advisory council	Results report	Next-year calendar changes



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Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

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Elementary Program Planning Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Planning area	Required entry
Priority student need	Name the need shown by data, survey results, or staff referral trends.
Curriculum focus	Identify classroom lessons, small groups, and schoolwide activities.
Responsive support	Identify the referral pathway, crisis procedure reference, and follow-up method.
Family communication	Identify planned family communication and language-access needs.
Evidence	Identify participation, student product, perception, or outcome evidence.



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Middle School Program Planning Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Planning area	Required entry
Transition focus	Identify sixth-grade entry, eighth-grade high school planning, and transfer supports.
Academic monitoring	Identify grade, attendance, behavior, and course-placement review routines.
Career exploration	Identify career cluster, interest, and ICAP preparation activities.
Responsive support	Identify referral, group, consultation, and family communication procedures.
Evidence	Identify completion, follow-up, and result measures.



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High School Program Planning Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Planning area	Required entry
Launch work	Identify schedule, transfer, intervention, orientation, and family-contact tasks before students return.
Credit and transcript review	Identify review windows, senior checks, recovery lists, and follow-up owners.
ICAP and postsecondary planning	Identify grade-level milestones and evidence of completion.
Closeout work	Identify final grade, senior completion, summer recovery, and transition tasks after the school year.
Evidence	Identify records, logs, completion rates, and annual results.



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Transcript and Credit Evaluation Form

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Student	Grade	Credits earned	Credits needed	Required courses remaining	Recovery need	Schedule action	Family contact	Next review



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Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

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Four-Year Plan and ICAP Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Planning item	Student entry or counselor note
Career interest or pathway	
High school course sequence	
Graduation requirements still needed	
Postsecondary options under consideration	
CTE, advanced course, dual credit, apprenticeship, military, employment, or certification interest	
Family review date and method	
Next action and owner	



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Parent Agreement and ICAP Input Form

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Family response item	Response
I have reviewed the student's current plan with the student or counselor.	Agree, need more information, or request conference.
Family concerns about course plan, graduation progress, or postsecondary steps	
Family questions about CTE, college, career, military, employment, financial aid, or supports	
Preferred contact method	
Counselor follow-up needed	



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Career Development Completion Standards

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Grade band	Minimum completion evidence
K-2	Career awareness lesson or activity, student reflection, and participation record.
3-5	Interest and strengths activity, career awareness exposure, and transition reflection.
6-8	Career cluster exploration, ICAP preparation activity, and high school transition planning evidence.
9-10	ICAP update, course sequence review, career pathway reflection, and postsecondary option exposure.
11-12	Postsecondary planning record, senior review, family communication when needed, and transition next steps.



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Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

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Time-on-Task Analysis Form

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Activity	Program component	Minutes or hours	Student group	Evidence	Appropriate duty review
Classroom lesson	Curriculum			Lesson log	Counselor-aligned
Credit review	Individual planning			Transcript or planning note	Counselor-aligned
Crisis response	Responsive services			Required documentation	Counselor-aligned
Advisory council preparation	System support			Agenda or minutes	Counselor-aligned
Routine clerical task	Non-counseling			Task description	Review for reassignment



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Senior Exit Survey

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Question	Response format
What is your confirmed postsecondary plan?	College, career, military, apprenticeship, certification, employment, undecided, or other.
What support was most helpful from the counseling program?	Short response.
What support did you need but did not receive in time?	Short response.
Did you complete required applications, financial aid steps, employment steps, or transition tasks?	Yes, no, not applicable, or need help.
What should counselors change for next year's seniors?	Short response.



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Ethical Guidelines Reference Sheet

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Area	Current expectation
Confidentiality	Explain confidentiality and its limits in developmentally appropriate language.
Mandated reporting	Follow current law and district procedure promptly.
Student records	Use approved systems and limit sensitive detail to what is necessary.
Referrals	Use current referral procedures and maintain follow-up appropriate to the school role.
Equity	Review access and outcomes by student group and respond to barriers.



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PROBE Results Evaluation Tool

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Evaluation item	Measure
Participation	Number and percentage of students reached by activity or grade.
Perception	Student, family, or staff feedback connected to the activity goal.
Outcome	Attendance, grade, credit, behavior, ICAP, completion, or transition data where appropriate.
Barrier	Implementation problem, staffing limitation, schedule conflict, or resource need.
Next step	Specific improvement action, owner, and review date.



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Responsive Services Referral Form

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Referral field	Entry
Date	
Student and grade	
Referring person	
Concern category	Academic, attendance, behavior, social-emotional, safety, family, health, transition, or other.
Concern description	
Prior interventions	
Urgency or safety concern	
Parent or caregiver contact	
Student Support Team or administrator notified	
Counselor action and follow-up	
Follow-up date	
Referral outcome or next step	



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Referral Contact Log Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Date	Student	Grade	Parent or caregiver contact	Agency or support contact	Action taken	Follow-up date	Comments



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Student Support Team Form Set

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Tool	Use
Functional behavior assessment	Used when the team needs to identify target behaviors and conditions before designing support.
Understanding root behaviors form	Used to examine possible causes, triggers, needs, and context before selecting intervention.
Behavior intervention plan	Used to define intervention, adult response, student support, and progress monitoring.
Individual student safety plan	Used when a student may present danger to self or others and a prevention and response plan is required.
Request for response	Used to request additional support from Student Support Services or the appropriate district team.



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Functional Behavior Assessment Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Section	Entry
Student, grade, school, and date	
Team members participating	
Target behavior stated in observable terms	
Frequency, duration, intensity, or pattern	
Setting, time, activity, or transition where behavior occurs	
Antecedents or conditions that commonly occur before the behavior	
Adult, peer, task, sensory, or environmental factors to consider	
Consequences or responses that commonly follow the behavior	
Student strength, interest, or protective factor	
Replacement behavior or skill to teach	
Data reviewed	
Team hypothesis and next step	



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Understanding Root Behaviors Form

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Section	Entry
Student concern or behavior pattern	
Student perspective or voice	
Possible unmet academic, social, emotional, health, family, or environmental need	
Known triggers, stressors, or transition points	
Strengths, relationships, and activities that support the student	
Supports already attempted	
Adult response that appears helpful	
Adult response that appears unhelpful	
Skill, accommodation, or environmental adjustment to try next	
Progress-monitoring evidence and review date	



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Behavior Intervention Plan Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Section	Plan detail
Target behavior	
Replacement behavior or desired skill	
Prevention and environmental supports	
Skill instruction or counseling support	
Positive reinforcement or recognition plan	
Adult response when concern occurs	
Escalation, crisis, or safety procedure reference	
Staff roles and communication plan	
Family communication	
Progress-monitoring measure	
Review date and revision decision	



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Individual Student Safety Plan Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Section	Plan detail
Student, grade, school, and date	
Team members and parent or caregiver contact	
Warning signs or situations that require adult attention	
Student coping strategy or help-seeking plan	
Trusted adults and locations for support	
Supervision, transition, or schedule support	
Emergency procedure or threat/self-harm assessment reference	
Items, spaces, or situations requiring restricted access or additional monitoring	
Re-entry plan after crisis or absence	
Follow-up date and responsible staff member	



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Request for Response Form

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Request field	Entry
School, date, and requesting staff member	
Student, grade, and student ID if required by district procedure	
Primary concern and urgency	
Current supports and interventions attempted	
Relevant attendance, academic, behavior, health, or service data	
Parent or caregiver contact completed	
Support requested from Student Support Services or district team	
Records or forms attached	
Requested response date	
Follow-up decision and owner	



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Annual Results Report Template

Schools may maintain the live version of this tool in a separate controlled template. The required fields and purpose are included here for consistent practice.

Report section	Required content
Priority addressed	Student need, grade band, and rationale.
Service delivered	Curriculum, planning, responsive service, or system support activity.
Students reached	Participation count and relevant student groups.
Results	Outcome, perception, or completion data.
What changed	Program change for next year based on evidence.
Barriers	Implementation barriers, staffing or schedule constraints, and corrective action needed.
Next-year action	Specific action, owner, timeline, and evidence for follow-up.

Maintaining the Handbook

The handbook should be reviewed on a regular cycle by counseling leadership. Revisions should be made when DESE revises the Missouri CSCP manual, SLPS revises board policy or administrative procedure, HR revises job descriptions, or the district adopts a new evaluation system.

Each annual review should consider whether the program model is still current, whether procedures match district practice, whether grade-level guidance remains useful, and whether schools have the resources needed to implement the program.

Counseling leadership should also review whether the handbook is being used. A manual that sits outside annual agreements, calendars, advisory council work, and results reporting will not change practice. The review process should ask principals and counselors which sections are useful, which sections need clarification, and which district procedures need to be linked more directly.

A revision log should be maintained outside the body of the handbook so the published manual remains clean and usable while still preserving the history of changes.

Implementation Responsibilities

District counseling leadership maintains the framework, coordinates revisions, and supports consistent implementation across schools. Principals protect the conditions needed for implementation, including time, role clarity, communication, and access to students. Counselors deliver the program components, document services, review data, and communicate results.



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The handbook should be part of onboarding for new counselors and principals. It should also be used during annual planning meetings, professional development, advisory council review, and end-of-year program evaluation.

When a school cannot implement a required element, the barrier should be named in the annual program review. Naming the barrier allows the district to distinguish between a practice issue, a resource issue, a staffing issue, and a policy issue.